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DOES THE MESSENGER MATTER? SOURCE FRAMING AND CLIMATE POLICY SUPPORT

Evidence from a survey experiment in Italy

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AI Declaration

Generative AI was not used to create any content for this thesis. Ideas and text are original to the author. AI tools, including Grammarly and ChatGPT, were used to assist with grammar, vocabulary, and syntax. ChatGPT was also used to clarify certain concepts and provide technical assistance with Stata, specifically to help interpret and correct commands in the software, for example to identify and correct syntax errors when code did not run as intended.

Abstract

Given the urgency of addressing climate change, understanding the factors that shape support for climate policy is particularly crucial. Drawing on source effect theory, individuals are expected to react differently to political messages depending on the perceived credibility, legitimacy, and trustworthiness of the communicator. This study aims to understand whether the identity of the actor proposing a climate policy affects public support for such a measure. Using original data from a survey experiment conducted in Italy, this thesis investigates whether support for a sustainability food labelling policy varies depending on whether the proposal is communicated by the European Union, the Italian Parliament, environmental NGOs, or independent scientific research agencies.

The study combines insights from source effects theory with contextual considerations about how the actors in the experiment are perceived in the Italian context. Findings show that communicator effects are generally limited. The Parliament framing is the only condition that consistently and significantly reduces policy support, while no statistically significant positive or negative effects emerge for the remaining framings. However, when examining the moderating role of trust, significant differences emerge for the NGO framing, suggesting that reactions to NGO communication are more strongly conditioned by prior levels of trust in the communicator. Overall, the findings suggest that source effects in climate policy communication may be limited and conditional, particularly for broadly supported policy measures, such as the one employed in this experiment.

Keywords: climate policy support, sustainability labelling, source effects, framing, source credibility, survey experiment, Italy

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Introduction

Designing effective and politically viable climate policies has been a central issue on political agendas for decades. Addressing climate change requires ambitious measures capable of transforming production, consumption, and everyday behaviour. However, the effectiveness of such policies depends not only on their design, but also on public support. Understanding the factors shaping support for such measures has become a central concern within political science and environmental policy research.

Over the past decades, a substantial body of literature has examined the determinants of climate policy support (Harring & Jagers, 2013; Drews & Van den Bergh, 2015; Harring & Jagers, 2018; Davidovic et al., 2020; Bergquist et al., 2022). Research has highlighted the importance of individual-level factors such as political ideology and environmental values, alongside more contextual factors such as economic conditions and levels of trust. More recently, growing attention has been devoted to the role of communication and framing in shaping public attitudes toward climate policy. Scholars have explored whether emphasising different aspects of a policy, such as economic benefits, public health benefits, or fairness considerations, can increase public acceptance (Lockwood, 2011; Bain et al., 2012; Evans et al., 2014; Petrovic et al., 2014; Dasandi et al., 2022; Degeling & Koolen, 2022). However, comparatively less attention has been paid to the role of the communicator in framing strategies. Citizens may evaluate the same policy differently depending on who promotes it. Research has long examined the interaction between messenger and message, exploring why some communicators are perceived as more persuasive than others, and this ties to considerations of credibility, trustworthiness, expertise, trust, and political alignment (Wilson & Sherrel, 1993; Pornpitakpan, 2004; Traberg & Van der Linden, 2022; Martin et al., 2022). Within climate policy research, however, evidence regarding source effects is more limited and mixed.

This thesis aims to contribute to this field by examining whether support for a climate policy proposal is affected by the identity of the communicator. More specifically, it addresses the following research question: “*To what extent does the source of a climate policy proposal affect public support among Italian citizens?*” Drawing on data from a survey experiment conducted in Italy, this thesis examines whether support for a sustainability food labelling policy varies depending on whether the measure is framed as being proposed by the European Union, the Italian Parliament, environmental NGOs, or independent scientific research agencies.

Findings suggest that communicator effects are generally limited, although important differences emerge across actors. Policies framed as communicated by the Italian Parliament consistently receive lower levels of support, particularly when potential economic costs are introduced. However, the remaining framings do not significantly affect support.

This thesis aims to contribute to the literature on policy support, framing effects, and source credibility. By focusing on the role of the source of policy proposals, as well as mechanisms of credibility and trust in shaping policy support, it seeks to extend existing research on communication strategies within climate policy. More specifically, it provides insights into how different actors may influence public acceptance of sustainability food labelling systems aimed at guiding individuals toward more sustainable dietary choices.

The thesis is structured as follows. The next chapter reviews the literature on climate policy support and framing effects, identifying the research gap this study aims to address. The theoretical framework develops the hypotheses guiding the analysis, first outlining contextual considerations regarding the expected persuasiveness of the different framings, and then introducing the expected moderating role of trust. The methodological chapter presents the research design, the survey experiment, and the operationalisation of variables. The following chapter presents and discusses the empirical findings, including both treatment effects and the moderating role of trust. Lastly, main findings, limitations, and avenues for future research are presented.

Literature review

This chapter begins with a review of the literature on environmental attitudes and determinants of public support for climate policy. Then, it explores the role of framing in climate policy research, outlining key findings and identifying the research gap.

2.1 Environmental attitudes and policy support

Addressing climate change requires ambitious policies with clearly defined targets. However, the effectiveness of such instruments ultimately depends on public support. Understanding the drivers of policy support is essential, as it can guide policymakers to design effective policies that will more likely be implemented and, thus, achieve their intended goals (Harring & Jagers, 2013; Drews & van den Bergh, 2015; Harring & Jagers, 2018; Davidovic et al., 2020; Bumann, 2021; Bergquist et al., 2022; Coleman et al., 2022; Hoyle & Rhodes, 2025).

In the environmental and climate literature, a key area of research concerns the discrepancy between environmental concern and policy support. While individuals may express high levels of awareness and worry about climate change, this does not automatically translate into support for policy measures (Kollmuss & Agyeman, 2002; Fairbrother, 2022). This gap highlights that policy support is influenced by a range of factors that extend beyond general climate concern (Harring et al., 2017; Drews & van den Bergh, 2015).

2.1.1 Individual-level determinants

Socio-demographic factors have been identified in the literature as influencing climate change beliefs, although empirical evidence is mixed (Lewis et al., 2019; Bergquist et al., 2022). One of the most consistent findings concerns gender, which has been identified as a strong predictor of climate change belief (McCright et al., 2016). However, its relationship with support for climate policy is weaker, as demographic effects on policy attitudes are often small or null (Bergquist et al., 2022). Similarly, education is generally expected to be positively associated with climate concern and policy support (Lewis et al., 2019), yet findings suggest a more complex relationship that varies across fields of education and policy domains (Harring & Jagers, 2018).

Stronger individual-level factors shaping policy preferences include personal values, worldviews, political ideology, and perceptions of climate change (Harring & Jagers, 2013; Harring et al., 2017; Fairbrother, 2022). Environmental psychology has emphasised the role of personal values in explaining pro-environmental behaviour, including support for policies. A central framework in this regard is the Value-Belief-Norm (VBN) theory developed by Paul C. Stern (1999). According to this model, human behaviour is the result of a causal chain in which personal value orientations shape

environmental beliefs, such as awareness of consequences and “ascription of responsibility”, which ultimately activate personal norms that guide behaviour (Stern et al., 1999, p. 84).

Empirical research supports this logic. A substantial body of research shows, for instance, that individuals with self-transcendent values tend to show greater support for climate policies than those with self-enhancement values, and that left-wing political orientation is associated with stronger pro-environmental attitudes (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015; Harring & Jagers, 2013). Climate change awareness and knowledge also play a fundamental role (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015). Individuals must perceive climate change as real, dangerous problem that requires personal or collective action. Without these beliefs, support for climate policies is unlikely to emerge.

Overall, individuals with a pro-environmental value orientation and a left-wing political orientation are generally more supportive of environmental policies (Harring & Jagers, 2013). Such factors are especially relevant in studies conducted in the United States, where climate change is a highly polarised topic and closely linked to party identification (Nisbet, 2009). Bumann (2021) argues that in such contexts, climate change beliefs and partisan affiliation are central drivers of policy support, emphasising the importance of communication strategies that highlight the private benefits associated with climate policies to overcome ideological resistance. Similarly, Fairbrother (2022) argues that greater attention should be paid to understanding public attitudes toward policy responses, rather than climate change beliefs alone. Together, these arguments suggest that future research should focus more closely on preferences for specific policy instruments and the factors shaping public acceptance of different climate policy designs.

Beyond values and ideology, the literature identifies additional individual-level factors that can shape attitudes, such as income and trust.

Although findings on the relationship between income, climate change beliefs, and policy support are mixed (Tjernström & Tietenberg, 2008; McCright, 2016; Hornsey et al., 2016), there is stronger evidence linking higher income levels to a greater willingness to bear the economic costs associated with environmental protection (Gelissen, 2007; Franzen & Meyer, 2010; Harring, 2013; Fairbrother, 2017). Trust emerges as one of the most relevant determinants of climate policy support. It includes trust in governments and politicians, in science, and in other people (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015) and it is particularly important in complex policy areas such as climate change, where individuals often rely on cues from experts and political elites (Harring et al., 2017). Institutional trust is especially relevant for market-based instruments such as carbon pricing, as citizens are more likely to support such measures when they trust policymakers to design and implement them fairly, effectively, and transparently (Harring & Jagers, 2013; Fairbrother, 2016; Kulin & Sevä, 2020).

Cross-national studies conducted in Europe provide strong evidence that trust in both politicians and political institutions is a key driver of support for climate policies, particularly those that involve economic costs or sacrifices (Fairbrother et al., 2019; Davidovic & Harring, 2020).

Importantly, these factors are closely interconnected. Harring (2013), for instance, finds that limited willingness to make economic sacrifices is associated with lower-income individuals, poorer societies, and lower levels of institutional trust. Broadly, both income and trust shape climate policy attitudes not only at the individual level but also at the aggregate level, as broader institutional and economic contexts can influence overall public sentiment and support toward climate measures.

2.1.2 Aggregate-level determinants

Economic factors play a crucial role in shaping public attitudes toward climate policy. Research shows that environmental concern and support for environmental protection are positively correlated with national wealth (Diekmann & Franzen, 1999; Gelissen, 2007; Franzen & Vogl, 2013). Two main theoretical perspectives explain this dynamic, namely the post-materialism hypothesis and the affluence hypothesis (Franzen & Meyer, 2010). The former argues that individuals in wealthier societies are more likely to prioritise post-material values such as environmental protection (Inglehart, 1995), while the latter suggests that environmental protection is a good that wealthier societies can more easily afford (Diekmann & Franzen, 1999; Franzen & Meyer, 2010). Economic context is then particularly relevant when investigating public support, as perceived and actual policy costs, including concerns about economic decline and unemployment, are central drivers of opposition (Fairbrother et al., 2025).

Institutional trust is closely associated with levels of corruption and the overall Quality of Government (QoG). In contexts characterised by high levels of corruption, inequality, and low trust in political institutions, citizens tend to be more hostile toward climate policies and economic instruments, as concerns often arise regarding whether such measures will be implemented fairly and effectively. In this regard, Harring (2013) finds that perceptions of the effectiveness of economic policy instruments are strongly influenced by levels of corruption. Similarly, Davidovic and Harring (2020) show that political trust and QoG are especially important for support for climate taxation, emphasising the importance of policy design and transparent communication regarding policy goals, expected effects, and the use of revenues. For instance, earmarking environmental tax revenues for specific purposes has been shown to increase public support for such measures (Fairbrother, 2022).

More broadly, QoG is considered a key condition for large-scale cooperation, particularly in the context of environmental policies, where citizens are often required to accept economic costs or behavioural changes for collective long-term benefits (Harring, 2013). The literature therefore suggests that, while values and ideological orientations may be relatively stable and difficult to change,

strengthening institutional trust and government quality may represent a more effective way to increase public support for climate measures.

Lastly, another relevant factor in this category is geography, as environmental conditions can directly shape climate policy support. Living in areas more exposed to climate change or extreme weather events may increase issue salience and strengthen support for climate policies by creating opportunities for public debate and awareness (Harring, 2013; Drews & van den Bergh, 2015).

2.1.3 Interaction effects

Individual and aggregate-level determinants have direct effects on climate policy support, but they do not operate in isolation. They can moderate the influence of individual-level predispositions, shaping the extent to which personal values, beliefs, and political orientations translate into policy preferences. This means that the same pro-environmental or ideological orientation may have a stronger or weaker effect on policy support depending on the broader social and institutional context.

Therefore, factors such as QoG and trust are relevant not only as aggregate-level determinants, but also as moderating variables influencing how individual predispositions translate into policy support (Hammar & Jagers, 2006; Davidovic et al., 2019; Fairbrother et al., 2019; Davidovic & Harring, 2020). For instance, an interesting study investigates the potential interaction effects between individual and aggregate-level variables, arguing that cross-national variation in the effects of pro-environmental and political value orientations can be explained by variation of QoG (Davidovic et al., 2019). Their findings show that in countries with high levels of QoG, pro-environmental and political value orientations have stronger effects on policy support than in low-QoG countries. Similarly, political trust has been shown to moderate the relationship between climate change beliefs and concerns and support for climate policies (Fairbrother et al., 2019). A European study conducted among individuals with low political trust, or those living in generally low-trust countries, found that climate beliefs are only weakly associated with support for fossil fuel taxes. By contrast, among high-trusting individuals, climate change beliefs are much more strongly associated with support for such policies (Fairbrother et al., 2019).

2.1.4 Policy-specific determinants

Finally, policy support has also been found to depend on policy design itself. Climate change is a particularly complex policy area characterised by significant uncertainty. However, while uncertainty about the scale and consequences of climate change poses challenges, uncertainty regarding the effectiveness of proposed solutions may be even more problematic for public support (Patt & Weber, 2013). When evaluating policies, scholars commonly emphasise dimensions such as effectiveness, efficiency, fairness, and political feasibility (Coleman et al., 2023). Public support is closely tied to these perceptions. In a recent study, Bergquist et al. (2022) find that perceived fairness and effectiveness are the strongest determinants for policy support. When evaluating a policy, citizens consider which groups are targeted, how costs and benefits are distributed, and whether the policy will alter the group behaviour and ultimately achieve its goals (Bergquist et al., 2022). In this regard, in recent years, scholars have increasingly argued that support for climate policy should be understood through a distributional conflict lens rather than a collective action lens (Aklin & Mildemberger, 2020). From this perspective, support depends on how citizens perceive the distribution of costs and benefits. Policies are more likely to gain support when they are perceived as both effective and fair, particularly when they impose greater costs on actors considered most responsible for emissions, such as industries rather than households (Coleman et al., 2023).

Consequently, policy design plays a crucial role in shaping public acceptance. A conjoint survey experiment conducted in Sweden examines policy attributes and their effects on public support for carbon mitigation policies (Coleman et al., 2023). Four categories were examined, namely the target of the policy, the nature of the policy instruments, the funder and administrator of the policy, and whether other countries are expected to adopt similar policies. The findings reveal that individuals prefer less coercive policies, funded by higher levels of government rather than local governments, adopted by other administrative units and by other countries (Coleman et al., 2023). Intuitively, individuals tend to prefer non-coercive measures, or “pull” measures, to “push” measures, as they typically entail lower economic and behavioural costs (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015). In addition to coerciveness, support is influenced by other considerations, most importantly those related to fairness. They are especially salient in discussions of carbon pricing mechanisms, which are widely regarded as among the most effective tools for reducing emissions but often face public opposition due to their perceived unfairness (Maestre-Andrés et al., 2019). In their meta-analysis of fifteen determinants of public opinion on climate taxes and regulations, Bergquist et al. (2022) find a stronger effect for distributive fairness on public support, compared to personal fairness, suggesting that citizens are more concerned with how costs and benefits are allocated across social groups than with how the policy affects them individually.

Overall, the literature highlights the complexity of the factors shaping public support for climate policies and identifies several avenues for future research. Scholars point to a need for more experimental research capable of identifying the causal relationship between different determinants of policy support and their interaction effects (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015; Heyen & Wicki, 2024), as well as for broader investigations across diverse geographical and cultural contexts (Bumann, 2021; Heyen & Wicki, 2024).

Beyond individual, aggregate, and policy-specific determinants, research increasingly emphasises the importance of communication strategies, as the way policies are communicated may influence how they are interpreted, evaluated, and ultimately accepted. Consequently, the following section introduces the concept of framing and its relevance to this thesis.

2.2 Framing

Climate change poses unique communication challenges: it is often perceived as distant in time and space, scientifically complex, and abstract in its consequences. As a result, scholars have increasingly focused on understanding how communication strategies can influence public responses to climate policy. Central to this discussion is the concept of framing, a mechanism that can shape how issues are interpreted and evaluated, thus making climate policies more salient, credible, and appealing to diverse audiences.

The following section outlines the key findings from this body of research. It first clarifies the concept, then discusses relevant findings from the studies, and finally identifies limitations and research gaps that this thesis seeks to address.

2.2.1 A definition

Framing has become a key concept across multiple disciplines, from psychology, sociology, linguistics, to political science and media studies. One of the earliest definitions comes from the Canadian American sociologist Goffman (1974), who conceptualises frames as interpretative structures that individuals employ to “organise what they see in everyday life” (Goffman, 1974, p. 21). Entman (1993) later provided one of the most widely cited conceptualisations of framing, defined as a process of selecting certain aspects of the “perceived reality” and “making them more salient in a communicating text” (Entman, 1993, p. 52). By emphasising certain elements over others, frames shape how individuals interpret and evaluate information. These processes, known as framing effects, are central to public opinion research, which examines how different presentations of an issue influence individuals’ attitudes and preferences (Chong & Druckman, 2007).

A first conceptual clarification in this context concerns the difference between equivalency and emphasis framing.

Equivalency framing, often referred to as valence framing, refers to presenting the same issue in either a positive or negative light, while keeping the underlying information “logically identical” (Druckman, 2001, p. 230). Levin et al. (1998) further refine the concept by distinguishing among three types: risky choice framing, attribute framing, and goal framing. This typology is still highly influential in contemporary research. A common example in climate policy research is gain-versus-loss framing, where a policy is presented either in terms of potential benefits (e.g., reduced emissions, improved air quality, job creation) or avoided losses (e.g., damages prevented, cost savings).

In contrast, emphasis framing refers to highlighting certain aspects of an issue over others, thereby framing “focus on different potentially relevant considerations” (Druckman, 2001, p. 230). Within this literature, scholars have distinguished between episodic and thematic frames (Iyengar, 1991), strategy and issue frames (Cappella & Jamieson, 1997), and value frames (Brewer & Gross, 2005).

The first distinction stems from the work of the American political scientist Shanto Iyengar, who examined how different presentations of television news influence individuals’ understanding of political issues, attributions of responsibility, policy views, and emotional reactions (Iyengar, 1991; Gross, 2008). In his framework, episodic framing presents issues through specific events or individual cases, while thematic framing places issues within a wider context, usually offering a more in-depth analysis (Iyengar, 1996). Through his experiments, Iyengar’s findings suggest that episodic framing tends to encourage individualistic rather than societal attributions of responsibility (Iyengar, 1996).

The distinction between strategic and issue frames originates in the work of Cappella and Jamieson (1997) in research on political communication and election campaign coverage. Media coverage has been categorised as either strategic or issue based. Issue framing emphasises policy matters, focusing on problems and proposed solutions, and candidates’ stances on certain topics (Rhee, 1997). Strategic framing focuses on campaign tactics, winning and losing, and candidates’ motives, often portraying politics as a competitive game (Patterson, 1994; Cappella & Jamieson, 1997). The effects of these frames on audiences are quite significant, as strategic framing has been shown to increase political cynicism and discourage positive evaluations of political actors and processes (Cappella & Jamieson, 1997; Zoizner, 2018).

Lastly, value framing presents a particular position as right and others as wrong by linking it to a core value (Brewer, 2001).

Common value frames emphasise principles such as equality, morality, ethics, or material considerations (Brewer & Gross, 2005; Severson & Coleman, 2015; Wolsko et al., 2016; Rhodeback et

al., 2018; Huang et al., 2022; Troy et al., 2025). Research suggests that value frames are particularly effective when they align with individuals' underlying value orientations, thereby increasing support for the position they advance (Rhodeback et al., 2018; Troy et al., 2025).

Together, these typologies clarify the conceptual foundations of framing within the broader literature, thus providing a useful framework for interpreting the wide range of studies in the field.

2.2.2 Framing effects in the climate policy research

Given the broad and multidisciplinary nature of the framing literature, this review focuses specifically on policy framing. Over the past decades, a growing number of studies have employed experimental designs to test framing effects in climate policy. However, assessing the effects is not straightforward, as individuals' responses to frames are conditioned by factors such as values, beliefs, ideology, and prior knowledge. Research consistently shows that framing effects interact with pre-existing psychological and ideological orientations (Chong & Druckman, 2007; Feldman & Hart, 2018). For instance, individuals with strong predispositions tend to be more resistant to frames that contradict their existing views (Chong & Druckman, 2007).

Among the earliest contributions to climate policy framing research is Lockwood's study, conducted in the UK in 2011. Although nationally focused and relatively dated, it is an influential contribution, as it highlights two insights that remain central today: framing effects are conditional and vary across subgroups by political identity, age, or gender (Lockwood, 2011). Later studies have built upon it, further investigating why and under what conditions frames succeed or fail (Walker et al., 2018). For instance, a "policy-frame match" and "message order effects" have been identified as relevant mechanisms for framing effectiveness. When citizens perceive the policy as actually addressing the issue emphasised in the frame, they are more likely to support it. Moreover, the order in which frames are presented, and not only their content, has been found to shape public responses. Frames prioritising public health elicited greater support when presented first, compared with the same wording when the climate change frame was presented first (Walker et al., 2017).

Much of the climate policy literature focuses on emphasis framing, examining whether highlighting different aspects of a policy influences public support. The underlying assumption is that framing policies emphasising immediate, concrete, and personally relevant aspects can increase public support. For instance, several studies examine frames that highlight co-benefits of climate policy, such as economic opportunities, financial savings, or public health improvements (Lockwood, 2011; Bain et al., 2012; Petrovic et al., 2014; Walker et al., 2018; Dasandi et al., 2022). Similarly, other studies examine how a local or global framing affects policy support (Degeling & Koolen, 2022; Evans et al., 2014). Research has also focused on equivalency framing, testing whether presenting policies in positive

or negative terms affects public support (Aklin & Urpelainen, 2013; Svenningsen & Thorsen, 2021; Dasandi et al., 2022). Often, studies combine multiple framing strategies within the same experimental design (Severson & Coleman, 2015; Dasandi et al., 2022). However, evidence regarding the significance of framing effects in climate policy is mixed, with some studies pointing in the opposite direction (Spence & Pidgeon, 2010; Schoenefeld & McCauley, 2015; Dasandi et al., 2022) or finding no statistically significant effects (Aklin & Urpelainen, 2013; Bernauer & McGrath, 2016; Singh & Swanson, 2017). A recent review of 121 experimental studies on climate and environmental policy framing raises methodological concerns and questions the robustness of studies reporting significant framing effects (Fesenfeld et al., 2024).

Overall, the literature suggests that framing is a powerful yet conditional tool: it can engage less concerned groups and enhance policy acceptance, yet it cannot fully overcome deeply held beliefs or partisan polarisation. Framing effects are not uniform, as they depend on the characteristics and values of the target audience. Effective climate communication, therefore, requires understanding the audience and the context and emphasising credible co-benefits of the proposed measure, as perceptions of effectiveness and fairness emerge as key drivers of policy support.

2.3 Research gap and contribution

Comparatively little research has examined the role of the actor communicating a policy and how this may shape public support. Most studies have focused primarily on message content, paying less attention to the source of the message. Individuals may be influenced in their evaluation of a policy depending on who communicates it, as the perceived legitimacy and credibility of the actor can shape public support. Therefore, this thesis investigates how different actors function as source frames and whether they affect levels of policy support.

In the environmental and climate literature, a few studies can be mentioned. Some findings suggest that the communicator can influence attitudes, as positive messages communicated by credible sources are associated with greater behavioural change. (Kim & Kim, 2014). Similarly, Bolsen et al. (2019) find that climate change messages communicated by credible actors, such as military leaders, increase perceptions of climate change as a serious threat. More closely related to this thesis's aim, Schaffer and Umit (2023) investigate different framing strategies of a climate policy based on the level of governance. Drawing on a survey of 4,000 respondents in Switzerland, they test whether citizens express greater support when a national climate policy is framed as fulfilling an international obligation under the Paris Agreement or as part of a broader domestic policy package. However, their findings find no significant difference in support between the two frames.

Yet, to the author's knowledge, no experimental study has directly compared EU-level versus national-level framing of climate policy, leaving the role of the communicating actor in shaping public support unclear. Addressing this gap is the central aim of this thesis. Over the past decades, the EU has positioned itself as a global leader in environmental governance, yet climate policies often encounter public opposition and political polarisation. Understanding whether support varies depending on whether a climate measure is communicated by the EU or by national governments can provide valuable insights for designing policies that are effective and widely accepted. Additionally, beyond national and EU-level actors, other actors, such as non-governmental organisations (NGOs) and independent scientific agencies, may offer valuable perspectives, as they often provide non-ideological and science-based information, which may influence citizens' evaluations, ultimately affecting policy support.

By experimentally testing how different governance and actor-level frames affect public acceptance, this thesis contributes to the literature by identifying which communicators are most effective in fostering public support for climate policy.

Therefore, this thesis aims to address the following main research question:

RQ: To what extent does the source of a climate policy proposal
affect public support among Italian citizens?

More specifically, through a survey experiment conducted in Italy, this thesis aims to address the following research question:

RQ: To what extent do different types of communicators, namely the European Union,
the Italian Parliament, environmental NGOs, and independent scientific research
agencies, affect public support for climate policy?

By addressing this question, this thesis contributes to understanding whether the communicator's identity affects public support for climate policy in the Italian context.

Theoretical framework

Citizens often rely on cues about the source of political messages when evaluating policy proposals. Building on source effects theory, this chapter examines how perceptions of the communicator shape the persuasive power of a message.

3.1 Source effects and policy evaluation

Understanding how individuals form political judgements is essential for explaining attitudes toward policy. When processing political information, citizens often rely on heuristic principles that help them make sense of complex information in an efficient and cognitively economical way (Mondak, 1993). In complex policy areas such as climate change, where citizens often lack information or technical expertise, these cues may become particularly relevant.

Source effects research stems from the literature on persuasion and has been extensively studied across several disciplines, including psychology, communication, and consumer behaviour. This body of research examines how characteristics of the message source shape the way individuals process information, evaluate messages, and ultimately form political attitudes (Kelman, 1958; Wilson & Sherrell, 1993). Findings consistently show that perceived credibility plays a central role in shaping persuasion (Hovland & Weiss, 1951; Wilson & Sherrell, 1993; Pornpitakpan, 2004). Credibility is generally understood as a combination of expertise and trustworthiness, meaning that sources perceived as knowledgeable, honest, and reliable are more likely to influence attitudes (Hovland & Weiss, 1951; Wilson & Sherrell, 1993; Pornpitakpan, 2004). Evidence also suggests that perceived similarity between the communicator and the audience can enhance credibility and persuasive impact (Swire et al., 2017; Marks et al., 2019; Traberg & Van der Linden, 2022).

This literature provides a general framework for understanding the factors shaping the persuasive power of different communicators. However, it does not specify which actors are more likely to be persuasive in a given context. To address this, the following section explores how these dynamics operate within the Italian context, which is the empirical focus of this study. In particular, it develops expectations about which communicators, namely the EU, the Italian Parliament, environmental NGOs, and independent scientific research agencies, are likely to be more or less persuasive and, consequently, to generate higher levels of policy support.

3.1.1 Expected persuasiveness of the EU and Italian Parliament framing

To assess the expected persuasiveness of the political actors included in the experiment, this section first examines attitudes toward the EU in the Italian context and then toward domestic political actors.

Attitudes toward the EU have changed significantly over the past few decades (Conti et al., 2024). As a founding member of the EU and a long-standing supporter of deeper integration, Italy has traditionally been regarded as a strongly pro-European country, often exhibiting more positive attitudes than the European average (Roux & Verzichelli, 2010; Conti & Memoli, 2015; Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021). However, over time, political elites have adopted increasingly critical positions toward the EU, thereby opening space for populist and Eurosceptic parties to mobilise and amplify these sentiments (Di Mauro, 2014; Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021). Growing scepticism has been linked to a series of economic and political crises, as well as perceived threats to national identity, particularly regarding immigration (Conti et al., 2024). Since the mid-1990s, political discourse surrounding the EU has become increasingly critical, especially following Italy's entry into the Eurozone and the adoption of the single currency, which were often associated with declining purchasing power and economic dissatisfaction among citizens (Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021; Conti et al., 2024). Subsequent crises further eroded support for the EU. The 2010–2011 economic crisis and austerity measures reinforced negative perceptions, and, more importantly, the migration crisis in the mid-2010s was a crucial turning point (Conti et al., 2024). As a primary entry point for migrants into Europe, Italy increasingly perceived a lack of solidarity and effective response from EU institutions (Dixon et al., 2018; Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021; Conti et al., 2024). These dynamics were further amplified by later governments, characterised by strong anti-EU rhetoric and threats to leave both the Eurozone and the EU (Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021). Overall, public support for the EU in Italy has eroded over time, leading many Italians to increasingly question the benefits and long-term viability of EU membership (Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021). This growing negative sentiment toward the EU is evident in the waves recorded by the Eurobarometer over time (Brunazzo & Mascitelli, 2021).

More recent data, however, suggest a partial recovery in support (European Commission, 2021, 2022, 2023, 2024, 2025). In particular, the EU's response to COVID-19, especially through the development of the NextGenerationEU recovery fund, of which Italy is the largest beneficiary, as well as the EU's response to the war in Ukraine, appear to have contributed to increased support for EU action (Bobba & Seddone, 2025).

Despite growing criticism of the EU, levels of trust in national institutions remain even lower. Eurobarometer data show that Italians tend to express higher levels of trust in the EU than in their domestic institutions. For instance, the Standard Eurobarometer 97 (2022) indicates that 46% of Italians

trust the EU, compared to only 33% and 30% who trust the Italian government and the Italian Parliament, respectively. More recent Eurobarometer data confirm this pattern, consistently showing lower levels of trust in national institutions compared to the EU. Similarly, a recent report by the Organisation for Economic Cooperation and Development finds that Italy performs below the OECD average in terms of trust in government, parliament, and political parties (OECD, 2024).

Broadly, political attitudes in Italy have often been characterised by widespread distrust in political institutions and political parties, as well as relatively high levels of political alienation, understood as a lack of political interest and engagement (Martini & Quaranta, 2015). This pattern of political dissatisfaction is closely linked to structural factors, including macroeconomic conditions and institutional performance (Martini & Quaranta, 2015). Several indicators illustrate this broader trend. Electoral participation has been declining over the past decades, with a particularly sharp drop in recent years. The 2022 national elections recorded a turnout of 63.9%. This 9-point decrease is the steepest decline between two elections in the country's history and one of the most significant decreases observed in post-war Western Europe (Chiaromonte et al., 2022; Emanuele, 2022). Moreover, the Italian party system has long been characterised by high electoral volatility and governmental instability, with 8 government changes since 2011 (Carteny & Piccolino, 2026).

In this context, Italian citizens tend to express greater confidence in local and European institutions, while trust in national political actors remains comparatively lower. Despite the rise of Eurosceptic actors, this broader pattern of institutional distrust toward national institutions has contributed to higher levels of confidence in EU institutions (Carteny & Piccolino, 2026; Angelucci & Vittori, 2023). In line with this, higher levels of trust are positively associated with political participation, including voter turnout, which in the Italian context tends to be higher in European elections than in national elections (Carteny & Piccolino, 2026).

Taken together, this evidence suggests that, although attitudes toward the EU have become more critical over recent decades, the Italian political context is characterised by more negative attitudes toward national institutions. These perceptions are expected to undermine the credibility, and consequently the persuasive power, of domestic political actors. This leads to the first hypothesis:

H1: Policy proposals communicated by the EU will receive higher levels of support than those communicated by the Italian Parliament.

3.1.2 Expected persuasiveness of the scientific framing

When assessing the persuasiveness of an independent scientific research agency framing, it is important to consider the role of expertise in political decision-making, and, overall, citizens' attitudes toward science and scientists.

First, an interesting consideration for the Italian context concerns public attitudes toward technocratic governance and the role of expertise in politics. In times of crisis, the appointment of unelected technocrats entails a trade-off between input and output legitimacy (Schmidt, 2011). While it reduces democratic participation, it signals non-partisan expertise and promises greater policy effectiveness (Merler, 2021). The Italian experience provides a particularly illustrative example. The 2011 technocratic government was initially perceived as a credible response to the economic crisis due to its association with expertise and neutrality. However, as Merler (2021) notes, support weakened as soon as the Prime Minister decided to compete in the national elections, suggesting that, once technocratic actors, and thus experts, become directly involved in politics, the credibility associated with their expertise may weaken, as they risk being perceived as part of the political establishment rather than as neutral problem-solvers.

Research suggests that the way scientific evidence is communicated can significantly shape public perceptions (Nisbet & Mooney, 2007), with particularly negative consequences when the inherent uncertainty of scientific evidence is either emphasised or omitted to support a political agenda (Vraga et al., 2018; Bolsen & Druckman, 2015). The politicisation of science can be particularly problematic for policy areas such as public health and climate change (Vraga et al., 2018; Incropera, 2016). The COVID-19 literature provides valuable insights into the relationship between scientific expertise, politics, and public reception of policy measures (Case et al., 2021; Hodges et al., 2022; Martin et al., 2022). During the pandemic, Italian political leaders extensively relied on scientific experts to promote public compliance, with doctors and scientists playing a central role in public communication and media coverage (Farjam et al., 2021). Experimental evidence from Italy during this time captures the importance of this relationship (Farjam et al., 2021). A study manipulating the source of information between scientific experts, political actors, or a combination of both, finds that individuals are more sensitive to pro-social motivations when messages are attributed to scientific experts. Support for restrictive measures declines when messages are communicated solely by political actors, and pro-social motivations overall weaken when scientific and political sources are combined (Farjam et al., 2021).

To further assess the expected persuasiveness of the scientific framing, it is important to consider levels of trust in science among Italians. Survey evidence consistently shows that scientists are among the most trusted sources of information, particularly when compared to political actors. Data

from the Ipsos Global Trust Index indicate that, in Italy, scientists are among the most trusted professions, while politicians rank last (IPSOS, 2019). Data from the European Commission's Special Eurobarometer surveys indicate that most respondents in Italy tend to believe that science has a positive impact on society (Eurobarometer 557). However, Italian citizens show more ambivalent attitudes regarding the role of scientists in political debate. Findings from Special Eurobarometer 557 indicate that, although a majority of Italians, but below the EU average, agree that scientists should intervene in political debates to ensure that decisions take scientific evidence into account, a large share (61%) believe that scientists should not intervene when such evidence is ignored. In this regard, Italy ranks among the countries most sceptical of direct scientific involvement in political discussions (Special Eurobarometer Report, 2024). These findings indicate a preference for maintaining a clear boundary between scientific expertise and political decision-making.

Taken together, this evidence suggests that, in the Italian context, expertise, particularly when perceived as independent of partisan politics, can enhance a communicator's credibility. Both experimental evidence and survey data suggest that scientific actors enjoy a credibility advantage in the Italian context, particularly compared to political institutions.

H2: Policy proposals communicated by an independent scientific research agency will receive higher levels of support compared to proposals communicated by the EU and the Italian Parliament.

3.1.3 Expected persuasiveness of the NGO framing

Unlike political institutions or scientific actors, NGOs occupy an intermediate position, as their credibility is not derived from formal authority or expertise, but rather from their association with values and their role within civil society.

From a theoretical perspective, NGOs are perceived as “non-political, non-profit-making and autonomous entities with potential for positively transforming social life” (Berhanu, 2002, p.120). A defining feature of NGOs is their value-based nature: they are guided by values in their activities and attract individuals who mobilise around shared and collective goals (Mikolajczak, 2023). NGOs can be understood as actors that fill gaps left by formal political institutions, intervening across multiple sectors and constituting a “major social and economic force at the local, national and international level” (Kuruvila, 2015, p. 21). In the literature, environmental NGOs (ENGOS) are conceptualised as part of a broader environmental movement. Within this network, ENGOS are typically the most institutionalised

actors, working alongside more radical activists to translate demands into forms that can access policy debates and influence decision-making processes (Berny & Rootes, 2018).

Considering survey evidence, Italian citizens show moderate levels of trust in NGOs. Data from the Edelman Trust Barometer (2026), for instance, indicate that approximately 51% of Italians report trusting NGOs to “do what is right”.

In Italy, NGOs have gained significant visibility in public debate, particularly due to their involvement in Search and Rescue (SAR) operations in the Mediterranean. These organisations have played a central role in rescuing migrants attempting to reach Europe via one of the world’s deadliest migration routes (Cusumano & Villa, 2020). However, their activities have also become highly politicised. NGOs have been accused of being a major “pull factor” for irregular migration. While initially praised for their humanitarian actions, NGOs were later accused of colluding with human smugglers and increasingly reframed in political and media discourse as “sea taxis.” Overall, particularly during periods when anti-immigration parties were in government, NGO activities were increasingly criticised and, at times, criminalised. Several measures, such as closing ports to NGO ships, were implemented to limit their operations and prevent migrants from reaching Italian shores (Cusumano & Villa, 2020). Although this is a specific case, it highlights how NGO credibility can be contested in politicised contexts.

However, since the focus of this thesis does not concern NGOs involved in the migration sector, perceptions associated with this highly politicised issue are less likely to directly influence how respondents evaluate the NGO framing in this study. In the environmental domain, NGOs are generally less controversial and perceived in a more neutral or positive light. Several ENGOs enjoy relatively high public visibility and recognition, such as *Legambiente*, *WWF Italia*, *FAI – Fondo Ambiente Italiano*, and Greenpeace, which are well-known for their activities for environmental protection and conservation of natural and cultural heritage. At the same time, ENGOs may still be associated with broader environmental activism, including more radical forms of protest. Groups such as *Ultima Generazione* (Last Generation) have gained considerable attention in the public and media discourse through non-violent but disruptive actions, such as blocking roads or targeting artworks with paint. While these actions aim to increase issue salience, they have also been widely criticised for disrupting everyday life, damaging cultural heritage, and overall being perceived as an ineffective approach to addressing climate change (Politico, 2024). Such associations may influence how the NGO framing is perceived.

Taken together, these considerations suggest that NGOs occupy an intermediate position in terms of persuasive effectiveness. They benefit from a credibility advantage over political actors, as they are

often perceived as more closely aligned with societal interests, yet their persuasive power is likely to remain lower than that of scientific actors, whose authority rests on perceived expertise and neutrality.

H3: Policy proposals communicated by an environmental NGO will receive higher levels of support than those communicated by political actors, but lower levels of support than those communicated by an independent scientific research agency.

This section developed more speculative expectations regarding the effects of different communicators in the Italian context. Drawing on broader political dynamics and survey evidence, it outlined how these actors are generally perceived and how such perceptions may shape support for climate policy proposals. However, communicator effects are unlikely to operate uniformly across individuals. Since the persuasive effectiveness of a communicator depends largely on perceived credibility, individuals' levels of trust in a specific actor are expected to condition how they evaluate and respond to policies communicated by that actor. The following section presents the expected moderating role of trust on communicator effects.

3.2 Trust as a conditioning factor

Political trust can be understood as an evaluative orientation toward political institutions and actors, reflecting the extent to which citizens believe institutions and politicians act competently and in the public interest (Hetherington, 1998; Norris, 2017). When citizens hold positive orientations toward their political institutions, they are more likely to accept the legitimacy of those institutions and the policies they propose. Consequently, political trust plays an important role in shaping public acceptance of policy interventions. This relationship becomes even more relevant when policies require citizens to make material or ideological sacrifices, as they need to trust that those measures “will produce societal benefits and not waste resources” (Hetherington & Husser, 2012, p. 2). A growing body of research shows that trust plays a central role in shaping public support for governmental actions and policies that involve uncertainty, risk, or personal sacrifice, characteristics that are particularly salient in the context of climate policy (Rudolph & Evans, 2005; Citrin & Stoker, 2018).

Therefore, individuals who trust a specific institution or actor are expected to be more supportive of policies communicated by that actor, as trust increases confidence in the policy's effectiveness and implementation (Fairbrother et al., 2021). On the other hand, lower levels of trust may reduce support for the policy measures proposed by that actor.

H4: The effect of the communicator on policy support is moderated by trust, such that individuals will express higher levels of support for policies communicated by actors they trust. In comparison, lower levels of support will be expressed with actors they do not trust.

Methodological framework

4.1 Research design

To empirically test the effects of source framing on policy support, this thesis employs a survey experiment to assess whether variations in the source of a climate proposal affect levels of support, and whether trust moderates these effects.

Survey experiments are specifically designed to test the impact of a treatment on an outcome while controlling for other factors that may influence that outcome. In such a research design, individuals are randomly assigned to different treatment groups, allowing the researcher to isolate and identify the causal effect of the treatment (Creswell, 2014). They are popular research design in social sciences and are often praised for combining both internal and external validity. Randomisation of treatment conditions allows researchers to identify causal relationships, thereby strengthening internal validity. At the same time, when conducted with representative samples, survey experiments allow findings to be generalised to the broader population, which supports external validity (Barabas & Jerit, 2010). Nevertheless, survey experiments face several limitations with regard to external validity. Although they are “valuable tools for studying public opinion”, researchers must consider that findings may only apply to the subgroup represented in the sample, as achieving full representativeness is often difficult (Barabas & Jerit, 2010, p.227). Moreover, in survey experiments, external validity is not only a question of sample representativeness, but also of whether the treatments themselves are externally valid. Treatments should resemble realistic situations to ensure that findings are not simply “the product of an unrealistically powerful manipulation, one that rarely occurs in natural settings” (Kinder & Palfrey, 1993, p.27). This concern is particularly relevant for framing experiments, which have often been criticised on these grounds. Framing effects are frequently examined through exposure to a single frame, whereas in real-world settings, citizens are typically exposed to multiple, competing frames simultaneously (Sniderman & Theriault, 2004; Chong & Druckman, 2007). Consequently, when treatments are “overly strong or atypical”, the effects may not be generalised to the broader population (Barabas & Jerit, 2010, p.227).

4.2 Sampling and data collection

The target population consisted of Italian citizens aged 18 and over. Accordingly, the survey was administered in Italy and restricted to participants meeting these criteria.

The experimental data were collected online on the survey platform Qualtrics. Responses were collected between the 15th and the 28th of April 2026. Snowball sampling was employed to generate the sample. The questionnaire was initially distributed to the researcher's personal contacts, who were then encouraged to share it within their own networks. Social media platforms were used to reach a wider audience. To further expand the sample beyond the researcher's immediate network, requests to share the survey were sent to sports and cultural associations, aiming to reach respondents from different regions of Italy and increase diversity in age, socioeconomic background, and political orientations. Finally, a flyer containing a QR code was displayed within the university building to reach Italian students currently living abroad, as no residency requirement was specified.

Given that respondents were recruited based on accessibility, the sample constitutes a convenience sample. As a non-random sampling method, its main limitation lies in the difficulty of obtaining a sample that is representative of the broader population (Burnham et al., 2008). Despite the efforts to increase diversity, the lack of representativeness of the obtained sample is a limitation and poses a threat to the study's external validity.

4.3 Survey design

The survey experiment was designed and administered via Qualtrics. The questionnaire was structured as follows. The introductory page provided respondents with a brief overview of the study, including its purpose, target population, anonymous nature, use of the collected data, and estimated completion time. Respondents were then asked to provide informed consent before proceeding to the questionnaire.

The questionnaire begins with a section collecting sociodemographic information, including gender, age, level of education, area of residence, political ideology, and income. It then moves to a set of questions measuring environmental attitudes, such as beliefs about climate change, levels of concern, perceived individual responsibility, and willingness to make personal sacrifices. The third section examines levels of trust, both general social trust and trust in the actors included in the experiment.

Before exposure to the experimental treatment, an attention check was administered to ensure that respondents were carefully reading and understanding the questions. They were then presented with a brief introductory text encouraging them to pay attention before being randomly assigned to one of the experimental conditions. Random assignment ensures that any differences in outcomes across conditions can be attributed to the treatment, namely the identity of the communicator. Following

exposure to the experimental vignette, respondents were asked to indicate their level of support for the proposed policy measure (DV1). They were then presented with a second question introducing potential economic costs associated with the policy and asked to indicate their level of support again (DV2). At the end of the questionnaire, a manipulation check was included to verify whether respondents correctly identified the actor communicating the policy. They are regarded as “standards of best practices in experimental political science” (Varaine, 2022, p. 299; Mutz & Pemantle, 2015) to ensure that “an experiment has been conducted”, meaning that the independent variable has been successfully manipulated (Sansone et al., 2002, p. 244).

The full questionnaire is reported in Appendix A and Appendix B.

4.4 Treatments

The experimental design includes five conditions: one control group and four treatment groups. In the control group, the policy is presented without specifying a communicating actor. In the treatment conditions, the same policy is attributed to one of four actors: the EU, the Italian Parliament, environmental NGOs, or independent scientific research agencies.

To examine source effects on policy support, participants were exposed to a short vignette describing the proposal and its goals. Vignettes are commonly employed in social science research to elicit reactions to hypothetical yet realistic scenarios (Yalaz et al., 2025). They are defined as “systematically elaborated descriptions of concrete situations” (Alexander & Becker, 1978, p. 93) and may consist of “text, images, or other forms of stimuli” to which participants are asked to respond (Hughes & Huby, 2004, p. 37).

In this study, the vignette content, namely the policy description, remained identical across conditions, with the only variation being the actor communicating the policy.

Table 1. Vignette

Vignette for the control group
To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, the introduction of a mandatory sustainability label on food products is proposed. Such a label would appear on food packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.
Vignette for the treatment groups
To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, [ACTOR] proposes introducing a sustainability label on food products. Such a label would appear on food

packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.
--

Table 2. Treatment conditions

Treatment condition	Actor
Treatment 1 (Control group)	No actor specified
Treatment 2	The European Union
Treatment 3	The Italian Parliament
Treatment 4	Environmental NGOs
Treatment 5	Independent scientific research agencies

4.5 Case selection

A sustainability food label has been selected as the policy proposal for this study. Sustainability labels of this kind are a valuable strategy to support consumers in making more sustainable food choices, thus contributing to the urgent need for a transition toward more sustainable food systems.

This policy appears as a particularly suitable case for examining source effects on policy support for several reasons. It is relevant to all citizens, as it relates to everyday activities such as food purchasing; it is relatively easy to understand, and individuals are generally familiar with similar types of food labels, such as those that provide nutritional information or indicate product origin and production methods. At the same time, it avoids highly technical and strongly polarised policy areas that are more likely to trigger strong resistance. Importantly, sustainability labelling is not a restrictive policy measure, such as bans or taxes. While sustainable diets are widely considered essential for reducing the environmental impact of the food sector, public acceptance of policies promoting dietary changes remains contested. The literature therefore emphasises soft policy approaches over hard regulatory instruments, particularly given that food consumption is a highly personal and sensitive domain. Although more restrictive measures may be more effective, they often face strong public resistance (Reisch et al., 2013; Van Loo et al., 2017; Piracci et al., 2024). Information-based policies, on the other hand, such as education, communication campaigns, and labelling schemes, have been proposed as a particularly promising starting point for increasing awareness and guiding behaviour. They are widely used within the EU, with evidence suggesting positive effects on consumer behaviour (Capacci et al., 2012; Garnett et al., 2015; Van Loo et al., 2017).

Furthermore, the choice of this policy was motivated by methodological considerations. Since the study aimed to reach respondents across Italy, it was important to select a policy that would be broadly relevant and understandable regardless of local context, unlike measures such as traffic restrictions or parking regulations. Sustainability food labelling provided a realistic and credible policy scenario, allowing the survey to be distributed more broadly, thereby facilitating a larger sample.

Selecting a sustainability food label also strengthens the study's internal validity. Since the policy proposal remained identical across treatment conditions and concerned a relatively familiar and understandable issue, differences in policy support can more plausibly be attributed to the framing manipulation rather than to variation in respondents' understanding of the policy itself. Moreover, selecting a policy that is neither highly technical nor strongly polarising reduces the likelihood that reactions are driven primarily by ideological opposition unrelated to the treatment. At the same time, the use of a realistic and familiar policy proposal enhances the external validity of the study, as sustainability labels resemble information-based measures that citizens may encounter in everyday life.

Lastly, this policy is particularly relevant in the Italian context, where food is deeply tied to cultural identity, thus making food regulations politically sensitive. In recent years, Italy has exhibited relatively conservative attitudes toward food policies, such as the Nutri-Score labelling system, which has often been questioned for its scientific validity, framed as a threat to the Mediterranean diet and the “Made in Italy” brand (Fialon et al., 2022; Rizzo et al., 2025). Similarly, Italy has taken a firm stance against the production and sale of lab-grown meat, which is currently not authorised in Europe, as well as against the use of terms such as “burger” or “sausage” for plant-based alternatives (Parlamento Italiano, 2023).

Overall, sustainability food labelling emerges as a suitable case for testing source effects, as it allows the analysis to focus on the framing manipulation, while still addressing a relevant and salient issue, particularly in the Italian context.

4.6 Variables and operationalisation

4.6.1 Independent variable

The independent variable in the study is a categorical variable indicating the communicator to which respondents were exposed, namely one of the four treatment conditions or the control group.

4.6.2 Dependent variables

Two dependent variables were measured following exposure to the vignette. The first dependent variable captures baseline policy support. Respondents were asked: “To what extent would you support or oppose the proposed measure?” Responses were recorded on a 7-point scale ranging from “strongly oppose” to “strongly favour,” with an additional “I don’t know” option. The second dependent variable measures policy support under cost conditions. Respondents were asked to indicate their level of support for the same measure if it implied higher costs for food products with greater environmental impact. The question read: “To what extent would you **still** support or oppose the proposed measure?” Responses were recorded on a 7-point scale, with an additional “I don’t know” option. The word “still” was included and highlighted to emphasise the change in scenario and to assess whether respondents’ level of support remained consistent when cost implications were introduced.

4.6.3 Moderating variable

To examine the moderating role of trust, respondents were asked to rate their level of trust in each actor included in the experiment on a scale from 0 to 10. Measuring trust prior to treatment exposure was a methodological choice based on an ongoing debate in research regarding the placement of potential moderators within a questionnaire. One side of this debate highlights the risk of priming bias when covariates are measured before treatment exposure, as pre-treatment questions may increase the salience of certain considerations and influence respondents’ reactions to the treatment itself (Klar et al., 2020). The other side emphasises the risk of post-treatment bias, arguing that moderators should be measured before treatment exposure, since measuring them afterwards may introduce bias if the treatment itself influences respondents’ evaluations of the moderator (Montgomery et al., 2018; Albertson & Jessee, 2022; Blackwell et al., 2025). Scholars, therefore, suggest that researchers should carefully weigh the trade-off between the risks of priming effects and post-treatment bias, and that the decision should depend on the relationship between the treatment and the covariates in question, particularly whether the covariates are likely to be influenced by the treatment itself (Klar et al., 2019). Following this logic, trust was measured prior to exposure to the treatment to ensure it functioned as a pre-treatment moderating variable rather than as a factor shaped by the experimental manipulation. Measuring trust after exposure to the treatment could have influenced respondents’ evaluations of the communicator, making it difficult to determine whether observed differences reflected pre-existing levels of trust or reactions generated by the treatment. If moderators are affected by the treatment, estimates of conditional effects may be biased.

Results and analysis

5.1 Data preparation

Before testing the hypotheses, descriptive statistics were calculated to provide an overview of the sample characteristics. Sample sizes decrease across stages due to consent, attention checks, and survey completion.

Of the initial sample ($N=517$), 489 respondents provided consent to participate. To ensure data quality, an attention check was conducted before random assignment of treatments. Participants were asked to select a specific response (“Agree”) to verify that they were paying attention. Of 451 observations, 95% of respondents passed the check, reducing the sample to 430.

At the end of the questionnaire, a manipulation check was implemented to ensure that participants correctly perceived the treatment. Respondents were asked to identify the actor who communicated the policy. Out of 422 observations, 224 respondents (53%) correctly identified the actor. The high failure rate (46%) indicates that respondents did not fully process or recall the information about the actor presented in the treatment, suggesting the treatment was not perceived as intended. However, restricting the sample to only those who passed the manipulation check would result in a substantial reduction in sample size. Therefore, analyses are conducted both on the full sample and on a restricted sample including only respondents who correctly identified the communicator. This approach allows for a more precise assessment of treatment effects among respondents who were fully exposed to the experimental manipulation, while preserving statistical power in the full sample. Further discussion on the high failure rate is provided in the limitations section. Full descriptive statistics on the sample distribution are reported in Appendix C, Tables C1 and C2.

5.2 Descriptive statistics

The following section presents the descriptive statistics of the sample. Overall, the sample is characterised by a predominance of female, relatively young, and highly educated respondents, primarily living in urban and semi-urban areas, with predominantly left-leaning political orientations and lower- to middle-income levels. Respondents display strong pro-environmental attitudes, characterised by high levels of climate concern, perceived personal responsibility, and a willingness to lower their standard of living for environmental protection. Lastly, respondents report moderate levels of general social trust ($M = 4.876$). Full descriptive statistics of the sample are reported in Appendix C, Tables C3 and C4.

Each respondent was randomly assigned to one of five conditions. Among the 422 respondents who reached this stage of the questionnaire, the distribution across treatment conditions is approximately even, with group sizes ranging from 81 to 87 respondents. More details are reported in Appendix C, Table C5. To provide a clearer overview of the composition of the experimental groups, Table 3 reports descriptive statistics for key sociodemographic characteristics, environmental attitudes, and general social trust variables across the treatment conditions. The table assesses whether randomisation produced comparable groups across treatment conditions. Although these variables are not included in the main analysis, they were collected to evaluate the balance between groups and provide an overview of the sample characteristics.

Table 3. Balance table across treatment conditions

Variable	Control	EU	Parliament	NGOs	Scientific agencies
Sociodemographic					
Gender	1.699 (.535)	1.639 (.554)	1.75 (.742)	1.675 (.546)	1.586 (.495)
Age	3.318 (1.72)	3.357 (1.662)	3.224 (1.628)	2.975 (1.837)	3.011 (1.795)
Education	3.965 (1.17)	4.012 (1.125)	3.845 (1.146)	4.012 (.955)	4.034 (1.136)
Place of residence	2.812 (1.19)	2.821 (1.055)	2.812 (1.075)	2.593 (1.058)	2.782 (1.104)
Ideology	3.883 (2.271)	3.756 (2.163)	4.342 (2.38)	4 (2.368)	3.881 (2.136)
Income	2.57 (1.411)	2.787 (1.473)	2.539 (1.076)	2.209 (1.038)	2.38 (1.235)
Environmental attitudes					
Climate seriousness	3.647 (.505)	3.81 (.395)	3.612 (.674)	3.778 (.612)	3.736 (.6)
Climate worry	3.694 (.913)	3.69 (.776)	3.565 (.944)	3.646 (.988)	3.776 (.918)
Personal responsibility	6.8 (1.831)	6.548 (1.935)	6.306 (2.488)	6.704 (2.058)	6.598 (2.121)
Willingness to make sacrifices	3.695 (.796)	3.651 (.956)	3.525 (1.067)	3.649 (.97)	3.771 (.801)
Trust					
General social trust	5.2 (1.993)	5.036 (1.661)	4.482 (2.379)	4.691 (2.195)	4.885 (1.985)

Note: Entries report means with standard deviations in parentheses.

This balance check provides further reassurance that no substantial differences in terms of sociodemographic, environmental attitudes, and social trust were present between treatment groups.

Having examined the composition of the experimental groups, the following sections present descriptive statistics for the main variables employed in the analysis, namely policy support (DV1), policy support when potential higher costs are introduced (DV2), and trust in the actors included in the experiment.

After exposure to the treatment, respondents were asked to indicate, on a scale from 1 to 7, their level of support for the measure. On average, policy support is high ($M = 6.05$), suggesting that respondents are generally very favourable toward it. When respondents are asked how much they would support the measure if it implied higher costs for products with higher environmental impact, average support slightly decreases ($M = 5.5$), suggesting that introducing costs leads respondents to express somewhat lower levels of support. Nevertheless, ceiling effects are observed in both variables, with relatively few respondents opposing the policy. This may limit the extent to which treatment effects can be detected, and it will be further discussed in the limitations section.

Levels of trust vary considerably across the actors included in the experiment. Independent scientific research agencies emerge as the most trusted actor ($M = 6.98$), followed by NGOs ($M = 5.90$). Trust in the EU is more moderate ($M = 5.21$), while the Parliament is the least trusted actor ($M = 3.50$). These differences are particularly relevant given the expectation that trust may condition the effect of communicator framing on policy support.

Full descriptive statistics are reported in Appendix C, Table C4.

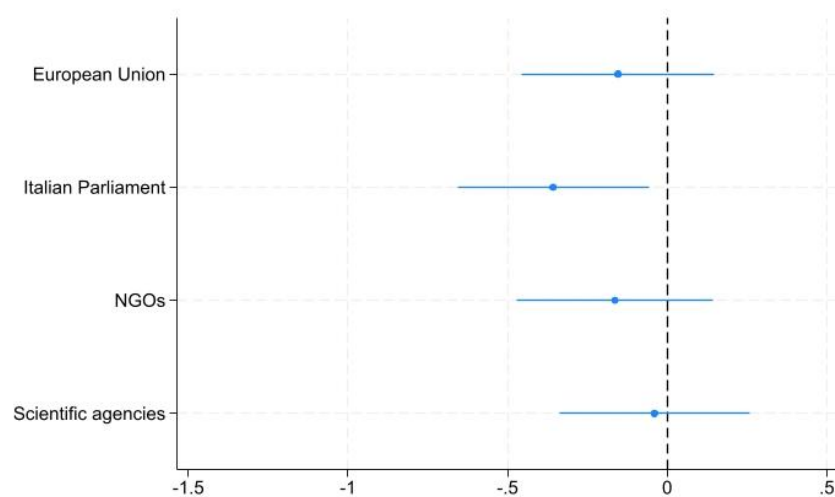
The following section presents the analysis. To estimate the effects of the treatments on policy support, Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) regression models are employed, and results are then presented through coefficient plots to facilitate interpretation.

5.3 Analysis: Treatment effects on policy support

This section presents the statistical analysis conducted to test this thesis's hypotheses. The analysis considers two dependent variables: policy support (DV1) and policy support when costs are introduced (DV2). Given the differences in sample size, the results are presented in two parts. The first section reports findings based on the full sample, and the second one focuses on the restricted sample. This approach allows for comparisons across samples and helps assess whether the observed patterns are consistent.

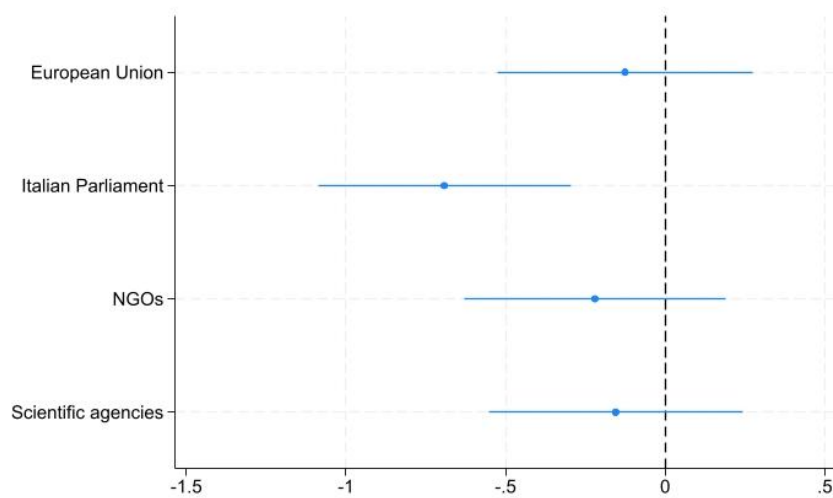
On a scale from 1 to 7, respondents in the control group report high levels of support ($M = 6.20$), indicating that attitudes toward the policy are already strongly favourable in the absence of any treatment. The low explanatory power of the model ($R^2 = 0.016$) further suggests that variation in policy support is only weakly associated with the communicator framing. Across treatment conditions, differences in policy support are generally small and statistically insignificant. The Parliament framing is the only condition associated with a statistically significant difference in policy support compared to the control group. Respondents exposed to this condition report, on average, a 0.36-point lower level of support compared to the control group ($p = 0.020$, 95% CI $[-0.66, -0.06]$).

Figure 1. Coefficient plots visualisation of the treatment effects on DV1 in the full sample (N=414)



Although support slightly declines under cost conditions, respondents in the control group are still broadly favourable toward the policy ($M = 5.83$). Once again, the Parliament framing is the only treatment associated with a statistically significant effect. Respondents exposed to this condition report substantially lower levels of support compared to the control group ($\beta = -0.69$, $p = 0.001$, 95% CI $[-1.09, -0.30]$).

Figure 2. Coefficient plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV2 in the full sample (N=410)

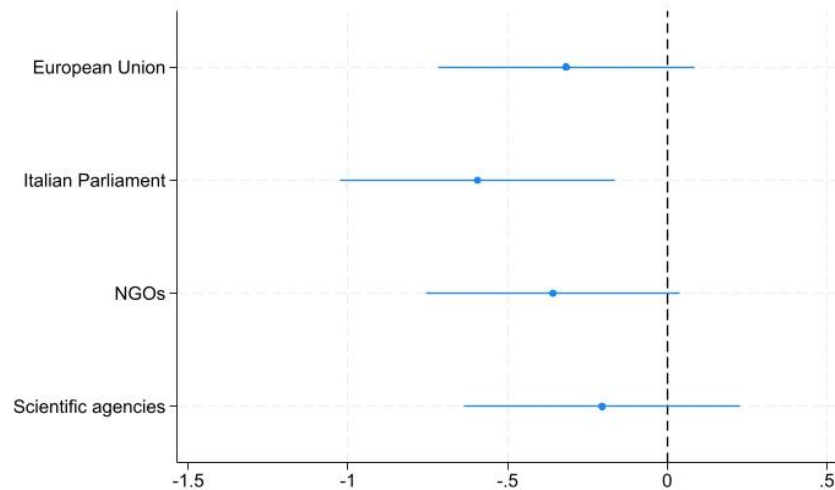


Overall, these results suggest that the communicator's identity plays a more important role when potential costs are introduced, particularly in the case of the Parliament, which significantly reduces policy support.

To assess whether the results hold among respondents who correctly perceived the treatment, the analysis is replicated on the restricted sample, including only individuals who passed the manipulation check.

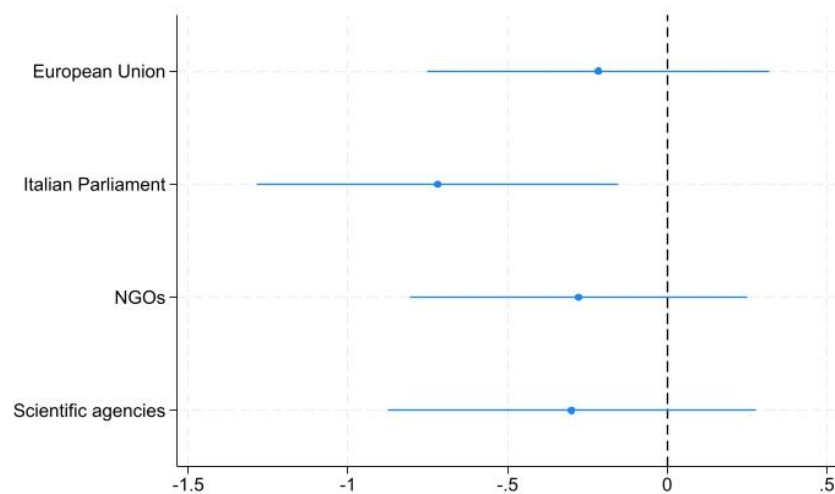
Baseline support remains high with a mean of 6.41 on a 1-7 scale. Compared to the control group, the Parliament framing is the only treatment showing a statistically significant negative effect. Respondents exposed to this condition report significantly lower levels of policy support ($\beta = -0.59$, $p = 0.007$, 95% CI $[-1.02, -0.17]$). This result is consistent with the findings from the full sample, reinforcing the conclusion that this communicator reduces policy support.

Figure 3. Coefficients plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV1 in the restricted sample (N=222)



Even when potential higher costs are introduced, support is still relatively high with a mean of 5.98 on a 1–7 scale. However, the explanatory power of the model remains low ($R^2 = 0.030$). The Parliament framing shows a statistically significant negative effect, reducing support by approximately 0.72 points ($p = 0.013$, 95% CI $[-1.29, -0.15]$). Notably, this effect is larger than in the baseline model without cost framing, suggesting that the negative impact of this communicator is amplified when costs are highlighted.

Figure 4. Coefficient plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV2 in the restricted sample (N=220)



Overall, the results confirm that the negative effect associated with the Parliament persists when costs are introduced and when the analysis is restricted to respondents who successfully passed the manipulation check.

5.3.1 Comparison across models

Across all regressions, a consistent pattern emerges regarding the effect of communicators on policy support. Most notably, the Parliament framing is the only treatment that systematically produces a negative statistically significant effect on support for the policy across both dependent variables. On the other hand, the remaining actors do not yield statistically significant effects in any of the models. While their estimated coefficients are generally negative, these effects are small and lack statistical precision, suggesting that these actors do not significantly influence policy support compared to the control condition. Interestingly, all treatments yield negative coefficients, suggesting that exposure to any communicator may slightly reduce policy support.

Comparing the results of the two dependent variables indicates that introducing potential higher costs reduces overall levels of support and increases the salience of the communicator. In particular, the negative effect associated with the Parliament becomes substantively stronger when costs are introduced, particularly in the full sample, where both the magnitude and statistical significance of the effect increase considerably. In the restricted sample, the negative coefficient also becomes larger in substantive terms, although statistical significance weakens due to the reduced number of observations and larger standard errors.

However, high levels of support are observed across all models, indicating ceiling effects, which will be discussed in greater detail in the limitations section.

Table 4. Treatment effects across models

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Policy support (DV1) Full sample	Policy support with costs (DV2) Full sample	Policy support (DV1) Restricted sample	Policy support with costs (DV2) Restricted sample
EU	-0.154 (0.153)	-0.126 (0.203)	-0.317 (0.204)	-0.216 (0.271)
Italian Parliament	-0.357* (0.152)	-0.692*** (0.201)	-0.594** (0.218)	-0.719* (0.288)
NGOs	-0.163 (0.156)	-0.220 (0.208)	-0.358 (0.202)	-0.277 (0.268)
Scientific agencies	-0.0396 (0.152)	-0.155 (0.202)	-0.204 (0.219)	-0.300 (0.292)
Constant	6.202*** (0.108)	5.833*** (0.143)	6.415*** (0.152)	5.976*** (0.201)
<i>N</i>	414	410	222	220
<i>R</i> ²	0.016	0.033	0.036	0.030

Note: Standard error in parentheses. The control condition serves as the reference category.

* $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

5.4 Analysis: Trust as moderator

Drawing on the theoretical expectation that trust shapes how citizens evaluate policy proposals, this section presents the results of OLS regression analyses examining whether individuals with higher levels of trust in a specific communicator exhibit different levels of policy support than those with lower levels of trust when exposed to the same framing condition.

Before estimating the models, a few adjustments were required. Since respondents were exposed to only one treatment condition, a new variable was constructed to capture each respondent's level of trust in the specific actor presented in their treatment vignette. This ensures that the analysis focuses on the relevant measure of trust associated with the communicator to which respondents were exposed. For instance, respondents assigned to the EU condition were matched with their reported trust in the EU, and so forth. This procedure ensures that the analysis relies on a trust measure directly relevant to the communicator to whom respondents were exposed.

To facilitate interpretation, this variable, originally measured on a 0–10 scale, was then recoded into two categories, namely low trust and high trust. Values ranging from 0 to 5 were classified as low trust, and values from 6 to 10 as high trust. Although recoding the variable into three groups (low, medium, and high trust) would have allowed for a more fine-grained analysis, this approach would have substantially reduced the number of observations in some subgroups, thereby limiting statistical power. Coding the variable into two categories provided a more balanced distribution of observations across groups. The models were estimated separately for respondents with low and high trust, with the control group serving as the common baseline in both regressions. As certain subgroups contain a limited number of observations, the results should be interpreted with caution.

Detailed subgroup distributions are reported in Appendix C, Table C6.

Results are presented in two parts: the first section reports findings based on the full sample, and the second focuses on the restricted sample, including only respondents who successfully passed the manipulation check. Across all models, the NGO framing consistently produces the clearest divergence between low- and high-trust respondents, suggesting that trust in this communicator specifically plays an important role in shaping policy support.

Comparing low-and high-trust respondents within each communicator framing reveals important differences in how trust conditions treatment effects.

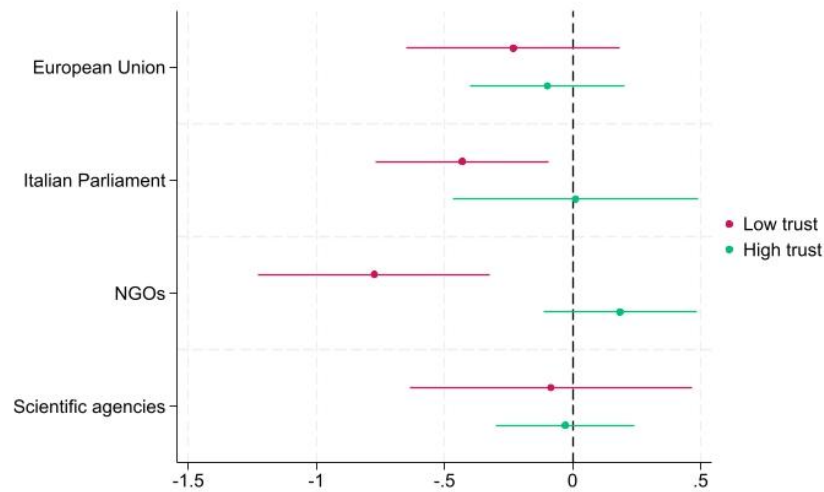
Among respondents with lower levels of trust, the Parliament framing is associated with a statistically significant decrease in policy support of approximately 0.43 points compared to the control group ($p = 0.012$, 95% CI $[-0.77, -0.10]$). Respondents exposed to the same treatment but reporting higher levels of trust display a small positive coefficient of 0.12 ($p = 0.961$, 95% CI $[-0.46, 0.49]$). However, the overlap between the confidence intervals suggests that trust in the Parliament does not appear to strongly moderate support within this framing. Differences between low- and high-trust respondents are most pronounced in the NGO framing. Respondents with low trust in NGOs report substantially lower levels of policy support, with an estimated decrease of 0.77 points compared to the control group ($p = 0.001$, 95% CI $[-1.23, -0.32]$). Respondents with higher trust in NGOs display a small positive coefficient ($\beta = 0.19$, 95% CI $[-0.10, 0.50]$). However, compared to the other framing conditions, the divergence between trust groups is considerably larger, suggesting that levels of trust strongly condition reactions to NGO framing. The remaining framings do not produce statistically significant effects, as the differences between low- and high-trust respondents are not significant.

Table 5. Trust effects of communicator framing on DV1 in the full sample

	(1) Low trust	(2) High trust
EU	-0.231 (0.212)	-0.098 (0.152)
Italian Parliament	-0.431** (0.170)	0.012 (0.243)
NGOs	-0.774*** (0.230)	0.185 (0.151)
Scientific agencies	-0.085 (0.280)	-0.028 (0.137)
Constant	6.202*** (0.114)	6.202*** (0.919)
<i>N</i>	234	264
<i>R</i> ²	0.058	0.012

Note: Standard errors in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Figure 5. Coefficient plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV1 across low and high trust respondents in the full sample



When potential higher costs are introduced, the overall pattern of results is consistent with the previous model.

Although the Parliament framing yields the strongest statistically significant negative coefficient among low-trust respondents, the NGO framing remains the most theoretically relevant finding for the present analysis. Unlike the Parliament condition, the NGO framing again displays the clearest divergence between low- and high-trust respondents. Respondents with lower trust in NGOs report a statistically significant reduction in support of approximately 0.76 points ($p = 0.018$, 95% CI $[-1.38, -0.13]$), while respondents with higher trust in NGOs report a small positive coefficient ($\beta = 0.08$, $p = 0.674$, 95% CI $[-0.31, 0.47]$).

Overall, these findings for both DV1 and DV2 suggest that NGO framing is particularly sensitive to levels of trust. Compared to the other actors, the NGO framing is the only condition in which trust consistently appears to shape respondents' reactions to the policy message. Individuals with lower trust in NGOs react more negatively to the framing and report lower levels of policy support, whereas respondents with higher trust display comparatively more favourable attitudes.

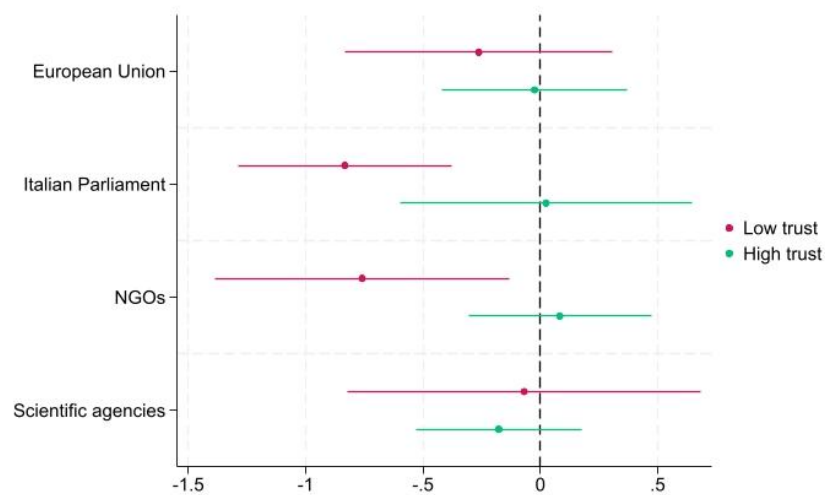
Table 6. Trust effects of communicator framing on DV2 in the full sample

	(1)	(2)
	Low trust	High trust
EU	-0.262 (0.289)	-0.025 (0.199)
Italian Parliament	-0.833*** (0.231)	0.024 (0.316)
NGOs	-0.759** (0.317)	0.083 (0.198)
Scientific agencies	-0.069 (0.381)	-0.177 (0.179)
N	234	260
R ²	0.065	0.007

Note: Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Figure 6. Coefficient plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV2 across low and high trust respondents in the full sample



The restricted sample analyses largely replicate the patterns observed in the full sample. Across both DV1 and DV2, negative framing effects remain concentrated among respondents with lower levels of trust in the communicator. In comparison, respondents with higher levels of trust generally display weaker or statistically insignificant treatment effects.

When comparing low- and high-trust respondents within each communicator framing, consistent with the findings from the full sample, the NGO framing continues to show the clearest divergence between low- and high-trust groups. Respondents with low trust in NGOs consistently report lower levels of policy support, whereas individuals with higher trust display coefficients closer to zero and, in some cases, slightly more favourable attitudes. Although the Parliament framing produces statistically significant negative effects among low-trust respondents, differences between trust groups remain comparatively small, as indicated by overlapping confidence intervals. By contrast, the NGO framing continues to display a more pronounced separation between low- and high-trust respondents, suggesting that prior levels of trust more strongly condition reactions to NGO communication.

Even when potential higher costs are introduced, the pattern of results is consistent with the previous model. The NGO framing is the only one displaying a clear and significant divergence between low- and high-trust respondents.

Nevertheless, these results should be interpreted with caution given the substantial reduction in observations across subgroups. See Appendix C, Table C6 for the distribution of observations included in this analysis.

Table 7. Trust effects of communicator framing on DV1 in the restricted sample

	(1) Low trust	(2) High trust
EU	-0.319 (0.293)	-0.315* (0.175)
Italian Parliament	-0.769*** (0.259)	0.085 (0.282)
NGOs	-1.026*** (0.308)	-0.015 (0.168)
Scientific agencies	-0.415 (0.477)	-0.165 (0.172)
N	117	146
R ²	0.118	0.032

Note: Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Figure 7. Coefficient plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV1 across low and high-trust respondents in the restricted sample

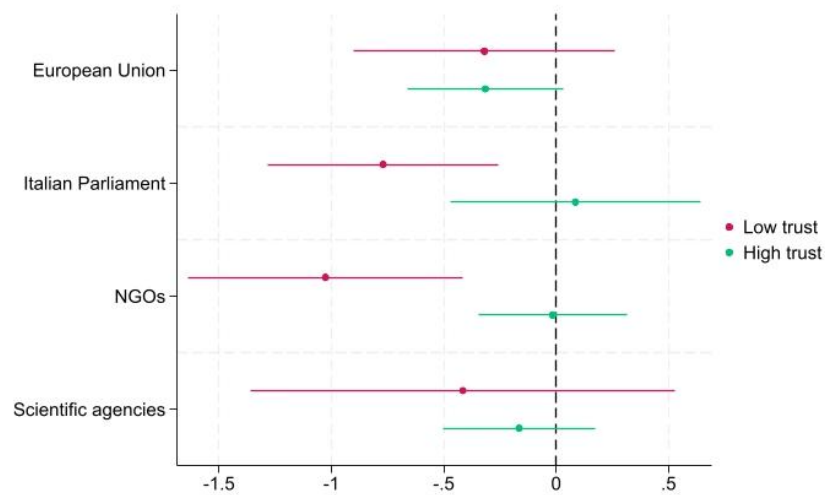


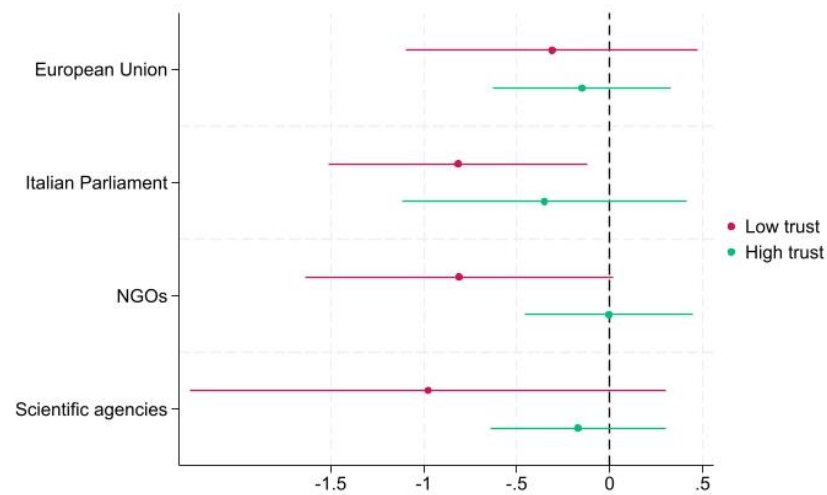
Table 8. Trust effects of communicator framing on DV2 in the restricted sample

	(1) Low trust	(2) High trust
EU	-0.309 (0.396)	-0.148 (0.242)
Italian Parliament	-0.814** (0.352)	-0.351 (0.386)
NGOs	-0.809* (0.418)	-0.004 (0.230)
Scientific agencies	-0.976 (0.646)	-0.169 (0.238)
N	117	144
R^2	0.064	0.010

Standard errors in parentheses

* $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$

Figure 8. Coefficient plots visualisation of treatment effects on DV2 across low and high trust respondents in the restricted sample



5.4.1 Comparison across models

Overall, the analyses examining the moderating role of trust provide evidence consistent with the expectation that trust conditions reactions to communicator framing. Across both outcome variables and in both the full and restricted samples, negative treatment effects are concentrated among respondents who express lower levels of trust in the actor communicating the policy proposal.

In particular, the Parliament framing produces statistically significant negative effects on policy support among low-trust respondents across both outcomes. Similarly, the NGO framing is associated with substantial reductions in support among low-trust respondents in most models. However, these effects weaken and become only marginally significant in the restricted sample when policy costs are introduced. The remaining treatment conditions do not produce statistically significant effects across the analyses. Similarly, among respondents with higher levels of trust in the communicator, treatment effects are generally weaker and statistically insignificant across both outcome variables.

Most importantly, the NGO framing consistently shows the clearest divergence between low- and high-trust respondents, suggesting that trust may play a particularly important role with this communicator. Although the Parliament framing occasionally yields the largest negative coefficients, differences between trust groups remain comparatively limited due to overlapping confidence intervals, thus suggesting that reactions to the Parliament framing vary less clearly across levels of trust.

Discussion

The aim of this thesis was to understand whether different sources communicating the same policy proposal, namely a sustainability food labelling measure, affect levels of public support. Overall, the findings suggest that communicator effects are generally limited.

Before discussing the hypotheses in detail, it is important to highlight a broader pattern emerging from the analysis. Across both samples and both outcomes, all framings produced negative coefficients, indicating that all communicator conditions reduced support levels compared to the control condition, in which no actor was specified. Although most of these effects were not statistically significant, the consistent direction of the coefficients is noteworthy. Therefore, the discussion of the hypotheses should be interpreted with this in mind, and the comparison between treatments focus on which communicators reduced support more or less strongly compared to the control group.

The results provide partial support for H1. While the EU framing did not significantly increase support compared to the control group, the Parliament framing consistently reduced support, particularly when potential economic costs were introduced. These findings suggest that source effects may operate more strongly through negative than through positive evaluations of political actors, meaning that more critical attitudes and lower trust in national political institutions appear to matter more than any credibility advantage associated with the EU.

H2 expected policies communicated by independent scientific research agencies to receive the highest levels of support. This hypothesis is not supported. Although descriptive statistics indicate that scientific agencies were the most trusted actor among respondents, this did not translate into significantly higher levels of policy support. This finding is particularly interesting given the theoretical expectations regarding credibility and expertise. Previous research has shown that scientific actors are often perceived as persuasive actors (Farjam et al., 2021; Martin et al., 2022). However, these findings suggest that high levels of trust in scientific actors do not necessarily produce stronger policy support. One possible explanation is that the policy proposal used in the experiment was not perceived as particularly technical or scientific. Thus, it may not have activated perceptions of scientific expertise strongly enough for the scientific framing to produce a significant persuasive advantage.

The findings regarding the NGO framing provide partial support for H3. It was expected that environmental NGOs would generate higher levels of support than political actors, but lower levels than scientific agencies. The direct effects of the NGO framing were not statistically significant. However, important differences emerged when considering the moderating role of trust, as it significantly conditioned responses to the NGO framing. This is theoretically important because it suggests that NGOs' persuasive power is less stable and more conditional than that of other actors. One possible

interpretation is that NGOs occupy an intermediate position in terms of perceived credibility. Individuals who already trust NGOs may perceive them as legitimate actors, while those with lower levels of trust may associate them with ideological activism or political agendas. Consequently, since the NGO framing is the only one in which trust moderates the treatment effects, H4 is partly supported.

The most relevant finding of this experiment, namely the negative effect associated with the Italian Parliament framing, is consistent with previous literature on the determinants of climate policy support. Support for environmental policies, particularly those involving economic costs, is strongly conditioned by institutional trust and broader perceptions of political effectiveness and fairness (Harring & Jagers, 2013; Drews & van den Bergh, 2015; Fairbrother, 2016; Kulin & Sevä, 2020).

The Italian society has long been characterised by comparatively low levels of trust in political institutions, widespread political dissatisfaction, and perceptions of governmental inefficiency and instability. These broader patterns of institutional distrust may help explain why respondents reacted more negatively to a policy proposal communicated by the Italian Parliament, supporting existing research that identifies institutional trust as a central condition for public acceptance of climate policies.

More broadly, the findings of this thesis align with research suggesting that framing effects are often limited, context-dependent, and conditioned by pre-existing attitudes and beliefs (Chong & Druckman, 2007; Lockwood, 2011; Feldman & Hart, 2018). Source framing effects may be limited in substantially altering attitudes when individuals already hold strong opinions about the policy itself. This may have been particularly relevant in this study, considering that the sample was characterised by sociodemographic and attitudinal characteristics that previous literature has consistently associated with higher levels of support for climate policy (Drews & van den Bergh, 2015; Harring et al., 2017; Feldman & Hart, 2018; Lewis et al., 2019; Bergquist et al., 2022).

At the same time, the findings suggest that communicator effects may become more relevant when policies involve perceived costs. Although support was still relatively high under cost conditions, the negative effect associated with the Parliament framing became stronger once higher costs were introduced, which aligns with literature emphasising the importance of trust for public acceptance of climate policies that involve economic sacrifices (Harring & Jagers, 2013; Fairbrother et al., 2019).

6.1 Limitations and future research

These results should be interpreted with caution, as several limitations of the study need to be addressed. With regard to external validity, although the vignettes were designed to appear realistic and salient to respondents, vignette-based experiments may still reduce perceived realism compared to real-world communication contexts. Moreover, despite efforts to diversify the sample, respondents were predominantly women, young, highly educated, and individuals with generally strong pro-environmental attitudes and left-leaning political orientations, making the sample not fully representative of the broader Italian population.

The overall composition of the sample and the high levels of environmental concern may have contributed to the generally high baseline levels of policy support observed in the study, which points to another important limitation of this thesis. Ceiling effects occur when participants' scores cluster toward the high end (Garin, 2023). Across both variables, respondents expressed strong support toward the measure, suggesting that the proposal was already well received, regardless of the framing. This represents a limitation, as it reduces the ability to observe treatment effects. When respondents already strongly support a policy, there is relatively little room for framing treatments to further increase or decrease support. Therefore, rather than suggesting that communicator framing is entirely irrelevant, the findings may actually reflect the difficulty of identifying framing effects in the context of a policy proposal that already enjoys broad public acceptance. At the same time, the fact that the Parliament framing consistently reduced support, despite this limitation, makes this finding noteworthy.

Another important limitation concerns the failure rate of the manipulation check. A substantial proportion of respondents (47%) were unable to correctly identify or recall the communicator associated with the policy proposal, suggesting that the treatment cue may not have been sufficiently salient for all participants. However, recent studies warn against automatically excluding participants who fail manipulation checks, as doing so may bias results and undermine the identification of causal effects (Aronow et al., 2019; Berinsky et al., 2014; Montgomery et al., 2018; Varaine, 2022). More specifically, removing respondents who fail manipulation checks may systematically exclude certain types of participants, since failure itself is correlated with individual characteristics (Berinsky et al., 2014). Although the high failure rate is an important limitation, the findings still suggest a consistent pattern. A study using survey data on support for climate policies compares respondents who passed and failed the manipulation check and reports interesting findings (Rubio & Revilla, 2021). Among 2,290 respondents, the manipulation-check failure rate was 58.8%. The authors identify differences between the two groups in terms of education, municipality size, and, most notably, interest in climate change. Respondents reporting lower interest in the topic were significantly more likely to fail the manipulation check, suggesting that failure was primarily due to inattentiveness (Rubio & Revilla, 2021). Therefore,

manipulation checks are generally recommended as a useful “means of validation”, but they should not automatically justify excluding respondents from the analysis (Aronow et al., 2019). Presenting “stratified results” has been suggested as a strategy (Berinsky et al., 2014, p. 752), which is why the analysis was conducted on both the full and restricted samples. Nevertheless, a pilot study could potentially have reduced the high failure rate by identifying issues related to wording and clarity (Aronow et al., 2019).

This limitation may also offer broader insight into the role of source effects in political communication, as it may itself be a substantive finding. The manipulation check used in this thesis was relatively difficult, as respondents were required to recall the actor at the end of the questionnaire without the option to return to the vignette. The high failure rate may therefore suggest that citizens pay limited attention to the source of policy messages and instead focus primarily on the policy content. In this sense, the weak source effects observed in the analysis may indicate that the identity of the communicator matters less than expected in shaping public evaluations. However, these findings should still be interpreted with caution, as ceiling effects suggest that source effects may have been particularly limited in this context, as support for the policy was already very high across treatment groups. Future studies could further investigate this issue by including manipulation checks for both the communicator and the policy content. Comparing failure rates across the two measures may provide additional insight into whether respondents pay greater attention to the substance of the policy proposal than to the identity of the actor communicating it. For instance, higher recall of policy content relative to communicator identity could suggest that source cues play a more limited role in shaping evaluations of proposals.

Future research could address these limitations by replicating the experiment with larger and more representative samples, thereby allowing for stronger claims regarding generalisability of and broader policy implications. If findings such as those of this study were confirmed in more representative samples, they would indicate strong public support for sustainability food labelling policies, which would contribute to more informed and sustainable consumer choices. To further assess source framing effects, it would also be valuable to replicate the experiment using more polarised and contested climate policies, as lower or more varied baseline levels of support may provide more favourable conditions for source effects to emerge. Lastly, considering the broad support for the policy even when potential higher costs were introduced, future studies could examine whether support remains high when cost increases are explicitly linked to products such as meat and dairy, which may activate stronger reactions.

Conclusion

This thesis investigates whether support for a sustainability food labelling policy varies depending on whether the proposal is framed as communicated by the European Union, the Italian Parliament, environmental NGOs, or independent scientific research agencies. Using original data from a survey experiment conducted in Italy, the study explores both the direct effects of communicator framing and the moderating role of trust. Overall, the findings suggest that the effects of communicators on support for climate policy are limited. Differences emerge across framings, as only one condition, the Parliament, consistently reduces support for the policy, particularly when costs are introduced. Contrary to expectations, no other framing significantly increased support compared to the control group. The moderation analysis shows that trust plays a significant role only for one framing, NGOs, suggesting that support for policies communicated by NGOs is more strongly conditioned by trust in the actor.

These findings contribute to the literature on climate policy research and framing by shifting the attention from message content to source, which is a comparatively underexplored area. Moreover, it provides original experimental evidence from the Italian context, which is a relevant case considering its political and institutional dynamics. Overall, these results provide limited evidence that the source alone can significantly shape support for climate policy, especially for policies that are broadly supported, such as the one examined in this study. Nevertheless, the strong negative effect associated with the Parliament framing suggests that communicator effects may operate more strongly through negative institutional cues and trust in domestic political actors.

Further experimental research across different contexts would be particularly valuable for understanding the factors shaping climate policy support and for informing policymaking on an increasingly urgent issue, as the findings of this thesis suggest that, while communication strategies and source framing may play a role, public support may depend more fundamentally on policy design.

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Appendix

Appendix A: Survey Questionnaire

Translated to English

As part of a Master's thesis project, you are invited to participate in a survey on public opinions regarding climate policies.

This survey is open to Italian citizens aged 18 and over.

Your participation is entirely voluntary, and all responses will be kept anonymous and used solely for academic research purposes.

The survey will take 3-5 minutes to complete.

Thank you for your time and valuable contribution.

1. Do you agree to participate in this survey, knowing that your responses are anonymous and that you can withdraw at any time?

- Yes, I agree
 - No, I do not agree
-

2. What gender do you identify with?

- Male
- Female
- Non-binary
- Prefer to self-describe
- Prefer not to say

3. What is your age?

- 18–24
- 25–34
- 35–44
- 45–54
- 55–64
- 65+
- Prefer not to say

4. What is the highest level of education you have completed?

- No formal education/ Primary school
- Lower secondary school
- Upper secondary school
- Bachelor's degree
- Master's degree
- PhD

- Other
 - Prefer not to say
5. Which situation best describes the area where you live?
- A large city
 - The suburbs or outskirts of a large city
 - A medium-sized town or small city
 - A small town or village
 - A rural area or countryside
 - Prefer not to say
6. Where would you place yourself ideologically?
- Extreme left
 - Left
 - Centre-left
 - Centre
 - Centre-right
 - Right
 - Extreme right
 - I do not identify with any political ideology
 - Prefer not to say
7. Which of the following best describes your personal monthly income (before taxes)?
- Under €1,000
 - €1,000 – €1,999
 - €2,000 – €2,999
 - €3,000 – €3,999
 - €4,000 – €4,999
 - €5,000 or more
 - I do not know
 - Prefer not to say

-
8. How serious a problem do you think climate change is at this moment?
- Not a serious problem at all
 - Not a very serious problem
 - A fairly serious problem
 - A very serious problem
 - I do not know
9. How worried are you about climate change?
- Not at all worried
 - Not very worried
 - Somewhat worried
 - Very worried
 - Extremely worried
 - I do not know
10. To what extent do you feel a personal responsibility to try to reduce climate change?
- Scale from 0 (not at all) to 10 (a great deal)
11. How willing would you be to accept cuts in your standard of living in order to protect the environment?

- Very unwilling
- Somewhat unwilling
- Neither willing nor unwilling
- Somewhat willing
- Very willing
- I do not know

12. Generally speaking, would you say that most people can be trusted, or that you can't be too careful in dealing with people?

Scale from 0 (you can't be too careful) to 10 (Most people can be trusted).

13. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means no trust at all and 10 means complete trust, how much do you trust the following actors?

- The EU
- The Italian Parliament
- Environmental non-governmental organizations
- Independent scientific research agencies

14. To ensure that you are paying attention, please select “Agree” for this question.

- Strongly disagree
 - Disagree
 - Somewhat disagree
 - Neither agree nor disagree
 - Somewhat agree
 - Agree
 - Strongly agree
-

“Below you will find a brief description of a public policy proposal.

Please read it carefully before answering the questions that follow”.

[Respondents were randomly assigned to one of the following vignettes]

[CONTROL]: To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, the introduction of a mandatory sustainability label on food products is proposed. Such a label would appear on food packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.

[EU]: To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, the European Union proposes introducing a sustainability label on food products. Such a label would appear on food packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.

[PARLIAMENT]: To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, the Italian Parliament proposes introducing a sustainability label on food products. Such a label would appear on food packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.

[NGOs]: To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, environmental non-governmental organizations (NGO) propose introducing a mandatory sustainability label on

food products. Such a label would appear on food packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.

[SCIENTIFIC AGENCIES]: To help consumers make more informed and sustainable food choices, independent scientific research agencies propose introducing a mandatory sustainability label on food products. Such a label would appear on food packaging and provide information about the environmental impact of the product, such as greenhouse gas emissions and water consumption.

15. To what extent would you support or oppose the proposed measure?

- Strongly Oppose
- Oppose
- Somewhat Oppose
- Neutral / Neither Favor nor Oppose
- Somewhat Favor
- Favor
- Strongly Favor
- I do not know

16. Now imagine that the price of the products will depend on this labelling. For instance, food products with a higher environmental impact would become more expensive due to this label. To what extent would you **still** support or oppose the proposed measure?

- Strongly Oppose
- Oppose
- Somewhat Oppose
- Neutral / Neither Favor nor Oppose
- Somewhat Favor
- Favor
- Strongly Favor
- I do not know

17. According to the previous text describing the policy and its goals, who proposed the measure?

- The European Union
- The Italian Parliament
- Environmental non-governmental organizations
- Independent scientific research agencies
- No specific actor was mentioned
- I do not know

Appendix B: Survey Questionnaire

In Italian, as administered

Questo sondaggio ha l'obiettivo di esplorare le opinioni dei cittadini italiani in merito alle politiche climatiche.

Il questionario fa parte di un progetto di tesi di laurea magistrale e richiede circa 5 minuti per essere completato.

Lo studio è rivolto a persone di età pari o superiore a 18 anni, in possesso della cittadinanza italiana.

La Sua partecipazione è volontaria e tutte le risposte saranno raccolte in forma anonima. Non verranno acquisite informazioni che possano identificarLa e i dati raccolti saranno utilizzati esclusivamente per finalità di ricerca accademica.

La ringrazio per il tempo che vorrà dedicare a questa ricerca e per il Suo prezioso contributo!

1. Fornisce il Suo consenso a partecipare a questo sondaggio, consapevole che le Sue risposte sono anonime e che può ritirarsi in qualsiasi momento?
 - Sì, fornisco il mio consenso
 - No, non fornisco il mio consenso
-
2. In quale genere si identifica?
 - Maschile
 - Femminile
 - Non binario
 - Altro
 - Preferisco non rispondere
 3. In quale fascia d'età rientra?
 - 18-24
 - 25-34
 - 35-44
 - 45-54
 - 55-64
 - 65 +
 4. Qual è il più alto livello di istruzione che ha completato?
 - Nessuna istruzione formale/scuola primaria
 - Scuola secondaria di secondo grado (scuole medie)
 - Scuola secondaria di secondo grado (istituto professionale, istituto tecnico, liceo, accademia)
 - Laurea triennale
 - Laurea magistrale
 - Dottorato
 - Altro
 - Preferisco non rispondere
 5. Quale situazione descrive meglio l'area in cui vive?
 - Una grande città
 - La periferia o i dintorni di una grande città
 - Una città di medie o piccole dimensioni

- Un paese o borgo
 - Una zona rurale o di campagna
 - Altro
 - Preferisco non rispondere
6. Dove si collocherebbe ideologicamente?
- Estrema sinistra
 - Sinistra
 - Centro-sinistra
 - Centro
 - Centro-destra
 - Destra
 - Estrema destra
 - Non mi identifico con nessuna ideologia politica
 - Preferisco non rispondere
7. Quale delle seguenti fasce di reddito descrive meglio il Suo reddito mensile personale (lordo)?
- Meno di €1.000
 - €1.000 – €1.999
 - €2.000 – €2.999
 - €3.000 – €3.999
 - €4.000 – €4.999
 - €5.000 o più
 - Non saprei
 - Preferisco non rispondere
-
8. Quanto ritiene che il cambiamento climatico sia un serio problema in questo momento?
- Per niente un problema serio
 - Non un problema molto serio
 - Un problema abbastanza serio
 - Un problema molto serio
 - Non saprei
9. Quanto è preoccupato/a per il cambiamento climatico?
- Per niente preoccupato/a
 - Non molto preoccupato/a
 - Abbastanza preoccupato/a
 - Molto preoccupato/a
 - Estremamente preoccupato/a
 - Non saprei
10. In che misura sente una responsabilità personale nel contribuire a ridurre il cambiamento climatico?
Scala da 1 a 10
11. Quanto sarebbe disposto/a ad accettare una riduzione del suo tenore di vita per proteggere l'ambiente?
- Per niente disposto
 - Poco disposto
 - Neutro / Né disposto né non disposto
 - Abbastanza disposto
 - Molto disposto
 - Non saprei

12. In generale, direbbe che ci si può fidare della maggior parte delle persone, oppure che non si è mai troppo prudenti nel trattare con gli altri?
Scala da 1 a 10
13. Su una scala da 0 a 10, dove 0 significa nessuna fiducia e 10 significa completa fiducia, quanta fiducia ripone nei seguenti attori?
- Unione Europea
 - Il Parlamento Italiano
 - Le organizzazioni non governative (ONG) ambientali
 - Enti di ricerca scientifici indipendenti
-

14. Per assicurarmi che stia prestando attenzione, selezioni “D’accordo” tra le opzioni.
- Fortemente in disaccordo
 - In disaccordo
 - Leggermente in disaccordo
 - Neutro / Nè in accordo né in disaccordo
 - Leggermente d'accordo
 - D'accordo
 - Fortemente d'accordo

“Di seguito troverà una breve descrizione di una proposta di politica pubblica.
La invito a leggerla con attenzione prima di rispondere alle domande successive”

[Respondents were randomly assigned to one of the following vignettes]

[CONTROL]: Per aiutare i consumatori a compiere scelte alimentari più informate e sostenibili, è proposta l'introduzione di un'etichetta obbligatoria che valuti la sostenibilità dei prodotti alimentari. Tale etichetta comparirebbe sulle confezioni alimentari e fornirebbe informazioni sull'impatto ambientale, come le emissioni di gas serra e il consumo di acqua.

[EU]: Per aiutare i consumatori a compiere scelte alimentari più informate e sostenibili, l'Unione Europea propone l'introduzione di un'etichetta obbligatoria che valuti la sostenibilità dei prodotti alimentari. Tale etichetta comparirebbe sulle confezioni alimentari e fornirebbe informazioni sull'impatto ambientale, come le emissioni di gas serra e il consumo di acqua.

[PARLIAMENT]: Per aiutare i consumatori a compiere scelte alimentari più informate e sostenibili, il Parlamento Italiano propone l'introduzione di un'etichetta obbligatoria che valuti la sostenibilità dei prodotti alimentari. Tale etichetta comparirebbe sulle confezioni alimentari e fornirebbe informazioni sull'impatto ambientale, come le emissioni di gas serra e il consumo di acqua.

[NGOs]: Per aiutare i consumatori a compiere scelte alimentari più informate e sostenibili, le organizzazioni non governative (ONG) ambientali propongono l'introduzione di un'etichetta obbligatoria che valuti la sostenibilità dei prodotti alimentari. Tale etichetta comparirebbe sulle confezioni alimentari e fornirebbe informazioni sull'impatto ambientale, come le emissioni di gas serra e il consumo di acqua.

[SCIENTIFIC AGENCIES]: Per aiutare i consumatori a compiere scelte alimentari più informate e sostenibili, enti indipendenti di ricerca scientifica propongono l'introduzione di un'etichetta obbligatoria che valuti la sostenibilità dei prodotti alimentari. Tale etichetta comparirebbe sulle

confezioni alimentari e fornirebbe informazioni sull'impatto ambientale, come le emissioni di gas serra e il consumo di acqua.

15. Quanto sarebbe contrario/a o favorevole alla misura proposta?

- Fortemente contrario/a
- Contrario/a
- Abbastanza contrario/a
- Neutro/ Né favorevole né contrario/a
- Abbastanza favorevole
- Favorevole
- Fortemente favorevole
- Non saprei

16. Ora immagini che il prezzo dei prodotti dipenda da questa etichetta. Ad esempio, i prodotti alimentari con un impatto ambientale più elevato diventerebbero più costosi a causa di questa nuova etichetta. In che misura sarebbe **ancora** contrario/a o favorevole alla proposta?

- Fortemente contrario/a
- Contrario/a
- Abbastanza contrario/a
- Neutro/ Né favorevole né contrario/a
- Abbastanza favorevole
- Favorevole
- Fortemente favorevole
- Non saprei

17. Secondo il testo precedente che descrive la proposta di questa politica (introduzione obbligatoria di un'etichetta sostenibile sui prodotti alimentari), chi proponeva l'introduzione di tale misura?

- L'Unione Europea
- Il Parlamento Italiano
- Organizzazioni non governative (ONG) ambientali
- Enti indipendenti di ricerca scientifica
- Non è stato indicato alcun attore specifico
- Non saprei

Appendix C: Descriptive statistics and distribution

Table C1. Attention check results

Result	N	%
Passed	430	95.34
Failed	21	4.66
Total	451	100

Table C2. Manipulation check results

Result	N	%
Passed	224	53
Failed	198	47
Total	422	100

Table C3. Sociodemographic

Variable	Category	N	%
Gender	Female	282	61.30
	Male	169	36.74
	Other	9	1.96
Age group	18-24	103	22.10
	25-34	110	23.61
	35-44	39	8.37
	45-54	72	15.45
	55-64	98	21.03
	65+	44	9.44
Education	No formal education/ Primary school	4	0.86
	Lower secondary school	25	5.38

	Upper secondary school	161	34.62
	Bachelor's degree	86	18.49
	Master's degree	168	36.13
	PhD	13	2.80
	Other	8	1.72
Place of residence	A large city	82	17.60
	The suburbs or outskirts of a large city	103	22.10
	A medium-sized town or small city	140	30.04
	A small town or village	131	28.11
	A rural area or countryside	7	1.50
Ideology	Extreme left	16	3.66
	Left	135	30.89
	Center-left	106	24.26
	Center	35	8.01
	Center-right	40	9.15
	Right	19	4.35
	Extreme right	3	0.69
	No ideology	83	18.99
Income	Under €1,000	77	18.97
	€1,000 – €1,999	166	40.89
	€2,000 – €2,999	104	25.62
	€3,000 – €3,999	26	6.40
	€4,000 – €4,999	9	2.22
	€5,000 or more	24	5.91

Table C4. Descriptive statistics

Variable	N	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min	Max
Climate seriousness	461	3.711	.576	1	5
Climate worry	455	3.666	.902	1	5
Personal responsibility	461	6.575	2.083	0	10
Willingness to make sacrifices	442	3.658	.905	1	5
General social trust	452	4.876	2.048	0	10
Trust in EU	452	5.215	2.307	0	10
Trust in Parliament	452	3.502	2.34	0	10
Trust in NGOs	452	5.905	2.459	0	10
Trust in scientific agencies	452	6.985	2.183	0	10
Policy support (DV1)	420	6.05	.996	1	7
Policy support when costs are introduced (DV2)	417	5.566	1.345	1	7
Policy support (DV1)	222	6.117	.982	1	7
Policy support when costs are introduced (DV2)	220	5.682	1.296	1	7

Table C5. Distribution across treatment conditions

Treatment condition	N	%
Control group	85	20.1
EU	84	19.9
Italian Parliament	83	19.7
Environmental NGOs	87	20.6
Scientific agencies	83	19.7
Total	422	100

Table C6. Distribution of observations across trust-treatment subgroups

Distribution in the low-trust group

Treatments	Freq.
Control group	85
EU	36
Italian Parliament	71
NGOs	30
Scientific agencies	17
Total	239

Distributions in the high-trust group

Treatments	Freq.
Control group	85
EU	48
Italian Parliament	14
NGOs	51
Scientific agencies	70
Total	268